

Caramelized onion-sweet potato butter

Perfect for the holidays but great anytime, this spread is used very much like dairy butter and is **best served** at room temperature. Once you've tried the recipe as is, feel free to adjust the amount of oil, maple syrup, and tahini to your own taste. No matter what changes you make, remember two key instructions: the onion should be nicely caramelized, and the spread must be **pureed** until very creamy.

1 large sweet potato or Jewel yam (about 1 pound [500g])

1 large yellow onion, coarsely chopped

3 tablespoons olive oil

1 to 2 tablespoons maple syrup

1 tablespoon tahini

¼ teaspoon salt, or more to taste

Freshly ground pepper

1. Preheat the oven to 325°F [160°C]. **Bake** the sweet potato until soft, 40 to 50 minutes. Let cool, scoop out the sweet potato, and discard the skin.
2. Meanwhile, in a medium skillet, **cook** the onion in 1½ tablespoons olive oil over medium heat until soft and golden brown, 10 to 15 minutes.
3. In a food processor, **combine** the browned onion, 1 tablespoon maple syrup, the remaining olive oil, and the tahini. Puree until smooth.
4. Add the sweet potato, salt, and pepper to taste and **blend** again until very smooth and creamy. Taste and add up to 1 more tablespoon maple syrup if you feel it is needed. Let stand for about 1 hour before serving.

MAKES ABOUT 2 CUPS [500ML]

Roasted pepper hummus

Hummus is easy to make and **tastier** than store-bought any day. I particularly enjoy this version in the fall, when the variety of hot peppers is in full stride. I like using a fresh cayenne, roasted in a cast-iron skillet. The roasting helps the chile retain the spiciness but mellows the heat and expands the flavor.

If you prefer no heat in your hummus, **substitute** sun-dried tomatoes or a roasted red bell pepper for the hot pepper, or use roasted garlic instead of raw garlic. Add more tahini if you like a creamier hummus. Serve with diced cucumbers, tomatoes, and warm pitas.

1 fresh cayenne pepper, or more to taste

⅓ cup extra virgin olive oil [75ml]

3 cups cooked and drained chickpeas [500g]

Juice from 2 fresh lemons

5 garlic cloves

Chopped cilantro or parsley, for garnish

3 tablespoons tahini, preferably roasted

1. Make sure your kitchen is well ventilated. **Toast** the cayenne pepper in a dry small cast-iron skillet over medium-high heat, turning every so often, until lightly blackened all over. Remove the stem and coarsely chop the pepper.
2. **Blend** all ingredients except the garnish in a food processor until very smooth. Let stand for an hour or so to let flavors develop. Scrape into a shallow serving dish and drizzle additional oil on top. Garnish with cilantro or parsley.

SERVES 6 TO 8

note Fresh cayenne peppers can be hard to find, depending on the kind of fresh market you have available, or where you live. Substitute another hot pepper, such as jalapeño, or even a rehydrated dried chipotle or canned chipotle in adobo sauce.

Rosemary olive oil

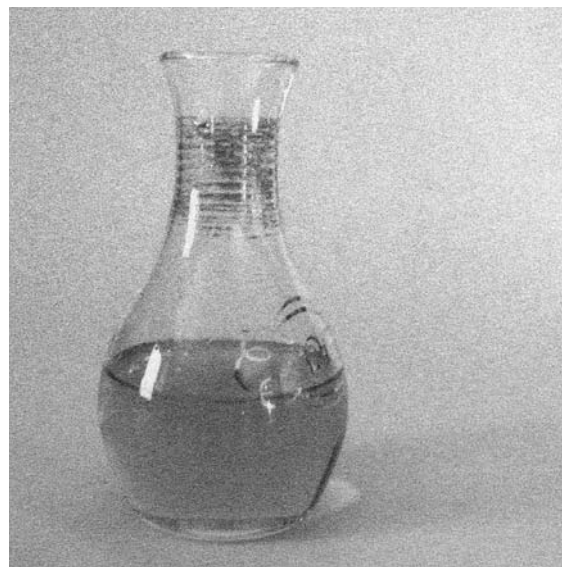
This has got to be one of the **simplest** appetizers ever conceived. I have given just the basic recipe, which, when used with exquisite extra virgin olive oil and fresh rosemary, is all you need. That doesn't mean you can't add a little garlic, a splash of balsamic vinegar, or another herb. Dip fresh, crusty bread in oil. Enjoy with olives, roasted red peppers, cheese, or any of the spreads in this chapter.

1 cup extra virgin olive oil [250ml]

4 to 6 sprigs fresh rosemary

Place the olive oil in small glass or ceramic bowl. Add the rosemary to the oil and let **steep** for at least 2 hours and up to overnight.

MAKES ABOUT 1 CUP [250ML]



Guacamole with tomato and cumin

Not much needs to be said about guacamole. It's beauty in taste and texture is self evident. Though I add cumin and coriander, plus a generous dose of fresh tomatoes, this recipe is essentially very simple.

4 plum tomatoes, seeded and finely diced

2 ripe avocados

3 garlic cloves, minced

1 teaspoon ground cumin seeds*

1 teaspoon ground coriander seeds*

1 teaspoon salt

3 tablespoons finely diced red onion, rinsed under cold water, then drained well

Juice of ½ lime

In a bowl, **mash** all the ingredients until well incorporated but still chunky. Adjust any of the seasonings to your taste.

SERVES 4 TO 6

*If you can mash the ingredients in a suribachi (see page 13), use whole garlic cloves and whole cumin and coriander seeds. Crush in the mortar along with the salt, then add remaining ingredients and mix well.

chef's tip

Rinsing the raw onion removes its bite, which I sometimes find unpleasant in a mild dish such as this.

Tomatillo, roasted fennel, and garlic guacamole

4 tomatillos, husked and rinsed

1 fresh serrano pepper

3 garlic cloves, unpeeled

1 tablespoon canola or safflower oil

3 ounces fresh fennel bulb, sliced (about 1 cup) [90g]

1 teaspoon unrefined cane sugar

2 ripe avocados

1 to 2 teaspoons salt

3 tablespoons red onion, finely diced, rinsed under cold water and drained well

3 tablespoons coarsely chopped cilantro

1. **Preheat** the broiler with the rack set about 4 inches [10cm] from the heat. Spread the tomatillos on a baking pan and broil, turning with tongs once or twice, until they are lightly browned and softened, about 5 to 7 minutes. When done, chop and set aside in a bowl along with any juices.
2. Meanwhile, make sure your kitchen is well ventilated. **Heat** a cast-iron skillet to medium-hot. Dry-roast the serrano pepper, turning every so often with tongs, until it is lightly blackened all over. When done, remove the stem and coarsely chop the pepper; add to the tomatillos. In the same pan, while you are toasting the pepper, roast the unpeeled garlic. Turn over with tongs occasionally but allow to get slightly blackened, about 8 to 10 minutes. Peel, chop, and add to the bowl.
3. Heat the oil in the same pan, add the fennel, and cook until soft and lightly browned, about 10 minutes. **Flatten** the pieces of fennel with a spatula, where you can, to get as many sides onto the heat as possible. Coarsely chop.
4. In a blender or food processor, **combine** the fennel, tomatillos, garlic, pepper, and sugar. Puree until smooth. In a bowl, mash with the avocados until the ingredients are well incorporated but still slightly chunky. Season with salt. Stir in the onion and cilantro. Cover with plastic, setting it right on the guacamole to keep it green. Serve at room temperature.

SERVES 6

Toasted garlic and tomato bruschetta with olives and basil

This recipe has some serious flavor. Bruschetta, a classic favorite, is usually made with raw tomatoes on toasted bread rubbed with garlic topped with fresh basil. I add a little **punch** to the mix with toasted garlic and olives. If stir-frying, remember to keep the heat fairly low, because extra virgin olive oil has a lower burning point than other more refined oils.

8 pieces thick-crust Italian or peasant bread, sliced about ½ inch thick [1cm]

2½ tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

4 to 6 garlic cloves, sliced into thin slivers

6 large plum or small to medium vine-ripened tomatoes, finely diced

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1 teaspoon balsamic vinegar

6 to 8 kalamata olives, pitted and sliced

3 tablespoons shredded fresh basil

1. **Brush** the top of each bread slice with about ½ teaspoon of the olive oil and toast or grill until golden brown on both sides. Set aside on a serving plate.
2. Heat the remaining olive oil in a wok or medium skillet over medium-low heat. **Add** the garlic slivers and cook until nicely browned, stirring often, about 3 minutes. Add the tomatoes and cook for another minute or so, until they soften. Add a generous amount of salt and pepper and a splash of vinegar. Toss in the olives.
3. Top each piece of toasted bread with the tomato mixture. **Garnish** with basil and serve at once.

SERVES 4

Horseradish mustard dip

This zesty blend makes an excellent substitute for cream cheese or sour cream spreads. Use on sandwiches or for **dipping** **crudités** or crackers. Fresh horseradish is phenomenal in its potency but, sadly, seasonal. When fresh is not available, use a good bottled brand—meaning one prepared with just **horseradish** and vinegar. Stay away from versions with eggs and cream and preservatives, etc.

3 tablespoons grated fresh or bottled white horseradish

½ pound firm tofu [250g]

2 garlic cloves, crushed through a press

2 tablespoons fresh lemon juice

1 tablespoon apple cider vinegar

1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil

1 tablespoon stone-ground mustard

1 teaspoon soy sauce

1 teaspoon salt

Freshly ground pepper

1. If using fresh horseradish, **mix** in a food processor until as finely ground as possible. Add all the remaining ingredients and blend well.
2. If using bottled horseradish, first **puree** the tofu until smooth and creamy. Scrape down the sides of processor once or twice. Add the remaining ingredients and continue to blend for a minute or two until creamy.
3. For best results, cover and **refrigerate** before serving. The flavors become remarkably sharp after an hour or two.

MAKES ABOUT 1 CUP [250ML]

chef's tip

To use fresh horseradish, peel what you need and chop into small chunks then grind in a food processor. It will make quite a racket at first but eventually will smooth out. Blend and blend until ground down. Wrap any unused root in plastic and refrigerate.

Sun-dried tomato and roasted garlic spread with mint and maple

This spread goes especially well on crackers and warm baguette slices, but it would be **excellent** with crudités and can be thinned with extra oil to use as a salad dressing. A cold dollop is perfect on top of Cajun Tempeh (page 146).

1 head of garlic

10 sun-dried tomato halves, soaked in hot water until soft, then coarsely chopped

1 pound firm silken tofu [500g]

Juice of 1 lemon

2½ tablespoons olive oil

2 teaspoons cider vinegar

2 teaspoons maple syrup

1 teaspoon red miso

1 teaspoon nutritional yeast

6 to 10 leaves fresh mint, coarsely chopped

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1. **Preheat** the oven to 325°F [160°C]. Break the head of garlic into individual cloves. Skin them and cut off any hard bits on the ends. Coat the cloves lightly with 1½ teaspoons of the olive oil and cook in a covered baking dish for 30 to 40 minutes, or until golden and soft. You may toss them once or so while they are cooking.
2. Puree the roasted cloves in a food processor. **Add** the sun-dried tomatoes and blend again until well mixed. Add the tofu and blend again. Add the lemon juice, vinegar, maple syrup, miso, yeast, mint, and remaining 2 tablespoons oil. Puree until very smooth, at least 2 minutes, scraping down sides two or three times. Season with salt and pepper to taste.
3. Transfer the spread to a bowl and cover. Let stand 1 to 2 hours or overnight, if you have time, to allow the flavors to develop. **Serve** on crackers or a warm baguette.

SERVES 6 TO 8

White bean and roasted garlic spread

Dried beans, freshly cooked, will give you the most satisfying taste here, but, of course, canned beans can be substituted for convenience. A mixture of herbs contributes the most interesting flavor. Serve warm or at room temperature, preferably with Cumin Pita Chips (page 34).

1 head of garlic

2 tablespoons plus 2 teaspoons extra virgin olive oil

2 cups cooked white beans [330g]

2 teaspoons ground cumin

3 tablespoons fresh lemon juice

3 or 4 dashes of Tabasco sauce

1 tablespoon plus ½ teaspoon minced fresh herbs, such as oregano, thyme, and mint

Vegetable stock or soy milk (optional)

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1. Preheat the oven to 325°F [160°C]. Separate the head of garlic into individual cloves. **Skin** them and cut off the hard bits on the ends. Toss the cloves with 1 teaspoon of the olive oil to coat lightly and cook in a covered baking dish for 30 to 40 minutes, or until golden and soft. You may toss them once or twice while they are cooking.
2. In a food processor, **combine** the roasted garlic with the beans, cumin, lemon juice, Tabasco, 1 tablespoon minced herbs, and 2 tablespoons of the olive oil. Puree until smooth. If the spread is too thick, thin with vegetable stock or soy milk, adding 1 tablespoon at a time. Season with salt and pepper to taste.
3. **Scrape** the spread into a serving bowl (a dark-colored bowl will create the most dramatic presentation) and let stand for 1 hour, if you have time. Just before serving, drizzle with the remaining 1 teaspoon olive oil and garnish with the remaining herbs.

SERVES 6 TO 8

Orange-sesame dipping sauce

Here's a citrus-based sauce with a nice **tang** and serious bite. It makes a fine dipping sauce for almost any Asian dumpling and is a perfect as a **marinade** for tofu or tempeh.

3 garlic cloves, minced

1 teaspoon grated fresh ginger

½ cup fresh orange juice [125ml]

1 tablespoon plus 1 teaspoon toasted sesame oil

1 tablespoon plus 1 teaspoon rice vinegar

1 tablespoon honey

1 teaspoon soy sauce

1 teaspoon hot sauce, or to taste

½ teaspoon red miso

1 tablespoon minced cilantro

Salt and freshly ground pepper

Mix all the ingredients very well in a bowl. **Taste** and season additionally if necessary, remembering the flavors will brighten dramatically in the next hour or so. Let stand at room temperature for 1 hour before serving.

MAKES ABOUT ¾ CUP [200ML]

Chinese mustard dressing

It's almost too simple to be true, but this sauce is **amazing**. There are no fancy ingredients—they can all be bought in any Asian or gourmet grocery store—and it's **easy** to make. The combination of flavors, however, is distinctive. Use as a dipping sauce or over a crunchy salad.

1 tablespoon Chinese mustard powder
(hot or regular)

Hot water

½ cup plum sauce [125ml]

3 tablespoons rice vinegar

2 tablespoons toasted sesame oil

1 tablespoon soy sauce

1 teaspoon salt

1 tablespoon unrefined cane sugar

1. In a bowl, **blend** the mustard powder with just enough hot water to make a paste. Let stand for 10 minutes.
2. Add the remaining ingredients and blend well. For maximum flavor, cover and **refrigerate** for at least 1 hour before serving.

MAKES ABOUT 1 CUP [250ML]

Sweet and sour cherry-mango sauce

Here's my version of Chinese duck sauce, perfect for dipping spring rolls and other Asian dumplings. I think most people are familiar with the flavor of sweet and sour. This sauce is **distinctive** with cherries, mango, and raspberry vinegar. Tamarind paste, also known as Indian date, is used in barbecue sauces and Thai noodle dishes and chutneys (probably without your knowing it). It's **tangy**, slightly sweet, with a somewhat raisiny flavor. Look for it in jars of concentrated paste.

½ cup finely chopped onion [70g]

⅔ cup raspberry vinegar [150ml]

1 tablespoon vegetable oil

¼ cup unrefined cane sugar [50g]

1 cup frozen or pitted fresh cherries, coarsely chopped [150g]

1 teaspoon tamarind paste

1 mango, peeled, pitted, and coarsely chopped

1. In a nonreactive medium saucepan with a heavy bottom, **cook** the onion in the oil over medium-low heat until very soft but not brown, 5 to 7 minutes.
2. Add the cherries, mango, vinegar, and sugar. **Bring** to a boil, cover, and reduce the heat to a bare simmer. Cook for 10 minutes. Uncover and cook 10 minutes longer, stirring occasionally so the sauce does not stick to the bottom or sides.
3. **Pass** the sauce through a food grater or a fine mesh strainer and press until the solids are practically dry. Return to the pan, stir in the tamarind paste, and simmer uncovered for 5 minutes, or until the sauce is reduced enough to coat a spoon heavily.

MAKES ABOUT 1 ¼ CUPS [300ML]

Cumin pita chips

Once you try these, you are likely to become **addicted**. They are easy to make and especially good served warm. Pita chips can be made a few hours ahead. Place in a bowl, cover with a dishtowel or paper towels to keep them crisp, and store at room temperature. Reheat briefly if desired.

Pita bread, about 6 inches in diameter [15ml]

Crushed cumin seeds

2 teaspoons olive oil per pita

Coarse salt and freshly ground pepper

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F [175°C]. **Cut** each pita into 8 triangular wedges. Cover a baking sheet with parchment paper and lay out pieces of pita in a single layer. Brush the tops of the pitas with olive oil and dust lightly with cumin, salt, and pepper.
2. Bake for 15 minutes, or until lightly browned on top. **Turn** the chips over. Bake for 5 minutes longer, or until the chips are crisp and lightly browned.

SERVES 2

Mango avocado salsa

I love a good salsa—which is the Mexican word for sauce, by the way. The fresh flavors, from hot to sweet to tangy, all **rise together** in a crescendo of exciting sensations in your mouth.

This is the salsa that started it all. The combination of colors and **vibrant** tropical flavors never fails to get rave reviews. The recipe calls for two mangoes, but you may use a third, depending on how juicy and meaty they are; adjust the other ingredients as necessary. Serve over Curried Corn Burgers (page 102), as a relish, or with chips as a dip.

2 mangoes, finely diced

½ cup [125ml] coarsely chopped cilantro

1 small red bell pepper, finely diced

2 avocados, diced

½ red onion, finely diced

Splash of peach vinegar*

1 fresh jalapeño or serrano pepper, minced

Salt

Juice of 1 large lime, or more to taste

In a large glass or ceramic bowl, **combine** the diced mangoes, red pepper, red onion, and jalapeño pepper. Mix well but with a light hand. Add the lime juice and cilantro and mix again. Fold in the avocados. Add a splash of vinegar and season with salt to taste. Let stand for 10 to 20 minutes before serving.

SERVES 4 TO 6

*This is a specialty item that may have to be ordered from a gourmet food catalog. If not available, use red wine vinegar.

Tomato and kiwi salsa with fresh apricots

For measurement's sake, your plum tomatoes and kiwis should be about the same size. And try to find **fresh** apricots for this salsa. If, however, they are not in season or have no taste (which is not unusual), substitute 1 mango or a large peach.

NOTE Due to the fragility of kiwis and apricots, this salsa has an especially short life. It's best eaten fresh.

3 kiwis, peeled and finely diced

3 garlic cloves, minced

4 plum tomatoes, seeded and finely diced

¼ cup coarsely chopped cilantro [60ml]

2 fresh apricots, finely diced

3 tablespoons lime juice

½ cup thinly sliced shallots [50g]

½ teaspoon salt

1 fresh serrano or jalapeño pepper, minced

1. In a large glass or ceramic bowl, **combine** all the ingredients except the lime juice and salt. Mix well but with a light hand.
2. Add the lime juice and salt to taste and mix again. If you have time, cover and refrigerate for 1 hour to let the flavors develop. **Toss** again and check the seasoning before serving.

SERVES 4 TO 6

Roasted corn and yellow tomato salsa with ancho chiles

Fresh corn is always preferable, and the new super-sweet hybrids have extended the season appreciably, but frozen will work without a hitch.

2 dried ancho chiles, stems and seeds removed

2 teaspoons olive oil

1 cup fresh or frozen corn kernels [120g]

½ pint yellow cherry tomatoes or 1 to 2 small yellow tomatoes, seeded and finely diced [150g]

1 small red onion, finely diced

1 fresh serrano or jalapeño pepper, minced

¼ cup fresh lime juice [60ml]

1 avocado, peeled and cut into small cubes

½ cup coarsely chopped cilantro [125g]

Salt

1. Bring a small saucepan of water to a boil and remove from the heat. **Add** the ancho chiles and cover. Soak for 20 to 30 minutes, or until soft. Coarsely chop the chiles and set aside.
2. While the chiles are soaking, **heat** the oil in a large cast-iron skillet over high heat. Add the corn and cook, tossing or stirring often, until lightly browned, 5 to 7 minutes. (Alternatively, if you don't have a cast-iron skillet, coat the corn lightly with oil and roast on a baking sheet in a 400°F [200°C] oven for 15 to 20 minutes.)
3. In a large ceramic bowl, combine the ancho chiles, corn, tomatoes, red onion, and serrano pepper. **Mix** well but with a light hand. Add the lime juice and mix again. Just before serving, season lightly with salt and fold in the cilantro and avocado.

SERVES 4 TO 6

Navy and black bean salsa with roasted yellow pepper

Needless to say, this salsa is for bean lovers. It's somewhat heartier than the fruit salsas, which makes it a nice side dish with rice and a salad.

2 large yellow bell peppers, roasted, peeled, and diced

1 cup cooked black beans, drained [165g]

1 cup cooked navy beans, drained [165g]

4 scallions, thinly sliced

½ cup coarsely chopped cilantro [125ml]

2 teaspoons minced fresh mint

1 fresh serrano or jalapeño pepper, minced

¼ cup fresh lime juice [60ml]

1 tablespoon cider vinegar

Salt

1. In a large glass or ceramic bowl, **toss** together the roasted peppers, black beans, navy beans, roasted peppers, scallions, cilantro, mint, and serrano pepper.
2. Add the lime juice, vinegar, and salt. **Mix** well. Season with salt to taste. Serve at room temperature.

SERVES 4 TO 6

THE NEXT TWO SALSAS are more authentically Mexican in style, more loose than chunky. Both are intensely flavored. You can use them as bases for sauces. To do so, puree until very smooth. Press through a mesh strainer and fry in a saucepan over high heat with a little oil. Add ½ to 1 cup [125 to 250ml] vegetable stock and simmer for about 15 minutes. Use where you want to plate a beautiful sauce underneath a burger, grilled tofu or vegetable, or swirled into a soup.

Chipotle chile, roasted pepper, and tomatillo salsa

Chipotle chiles, which are dried smoked jalapeños, add a wonderful **smoky flavor** to everything they touch. This richly flavored and exquisite-looking salsa has a beautiful blend of tastes—smoky, sweet, tart, hot, and tangy.

2 dried chipotle chiles, sliced open, seeds, ribs, and stem removed

2 garlic cloves, unpeeled

1 large red bell pepper

4 tomatillos, husked and rinsed

1 tablespoon unrefined cane sugar

2 tablespoons lime juice

¼ teaspoon salt

1. Preheat the broiler with a rack set about 4 inches [10cm] from the heat. **Pour** very hot water over the chiles in a small bowl and cover. Soak until soft, 30 to 40 minutes. Drain, coarsely chop, and set aside.
2. **Arrange** the garlic cloves, bell pepper, and tomatillos on a baking sheet and broil, turning with tongs, until the garlic is soft and spotted brown, 7 to 10 minutes, and the tomatillos and peppers are lightly blackened and softened, about 10 to 15 minutes.
3. Peel the garlic. **Peel** the skin off the pepper and scrape out the seeds.
4. In a blender or food processor, **combine** the chipotle chiles with the roasted red pepper, tomatillos, garlic, sugar, lime juice, and salt. Blend until coarsely chopped. Pour into a bowl and stir in cilantro. Season with additional salt and pepper to taste.

SERVES 4 TO 6

Basic vegetable stock

2 large onions, peeled and quartered

3 carrots, peeled or scrubbed and cut into chunks

2 to 3 celery ribs, cut into chunks

4 to 5 whole garlic cloves, peeled

1 bouquet garni*

Optional vegetables: parsnips, fresh fennel, bell peppers, mushrooms, corncobs

10 cups cold water [2.5L]

½ cup dry white wine [125ml]

2 tablespoons white wine vinegar or champagne vinegar

Salt, freshly ground white pepper, and soy sauce

1. **Add** the onions, carrots, celery, garlic, bouquet garni, and optional vegetables to a large pot. Pour in the cold water and wine and bring to a boil.
2. Reduce the heat to a bare simmer and cook, uncovered, 45 to 60 minutes. If you notice scum floating to the top, skim it off with a large spoon. **Taste** the stock after 45 minutes. If you feel the vegetables have given all they can give, strain and discard them.
3. Return the hot stock to the pot over low heat. **Stir** in the vinegar and simmer for 5 minutes. Season with the salt, white pepper, and a few drops of soy sauce to taste.

MAKES ABOUT 8 CUPS [2L]

*Use cheesecloth and kitchen string to make a fat bundle (2 to 3 inches [5 to 7cm] in diameter) containing fresh parsley and/or parsley stems, peppercorns, fresh thyme, and 1 bay leaf. The flavors of your bouquet garni can be varied to match the type of soup you're creating—meaning you could add cumin seeds, fennel seeds, star anise, or a cinnamon stick, for example, to complement a particular soup.

Roasted vegetable stock

Here's a recipe for a deep, rich, **savory stock**, perfect for soups or sauces. It's essential for French onion soup (page 52). With roasted vegetable stock, it's okay to use beets or even roasted tomatoes or tomato skins, as your stock will be dark-colored anyway.

½ celery root, peeled and coarsely chopped	2 beets, scrubbed and coarsely chopped
4 celery ribs, chopped	1½ tablespoons olive oil
2 to 3 large carrots, peeled and coarsely chopped	1 teaspoon salt
1 head of garlic, divided into cloves, peeled and left whole	10 cups cold water [2.5L]
3 shallots, chopped	½ cup red wine [125ml]
2 large yellow onions, quartered	2 tablespoons red wine vinegar or balsamic vinegar
	Salt and freshly ground black pepper

1. **Preheat** the oven to 400°F [200°C]. Place the chopped vegetables in a large bowl. Add the olive oil and salt and toss to coat. Spread out on a large baking sheet or in a shallow baking dish.
2. Roast the vegetables 45 minutes to an hour, **turning** with a wide spatula several times, until they are soft and nicely browned.
3. **Add** the browned vegetables to a large stockpot. Pour in the cold water and wine and bring to a boil. Reduce the heat to a simmer and cook, uncovered, 45 to 60 minutes. If you notice scum floating to the top, skim it off with a spoon.
4. **Taste** the stock after 45 minutes. If you feel the vegetables have given all they can give, strain and discard them.
5. Return the hot stock to the pot and set over low heat. **Stir** in the vinegar and simmer for 5 minutes. Season with additional salt and pepper to taste.

MAKES ABOUT 8 CUPS [2L]

Beautiful black bean and avocado Soup

Cook this soup slowly and drink in its beauty and aroma. The taste is righteous. Silky **avocado** may sound like a strange addition to a bean soup, yet, in fact, it works perfectly to accent and beautify the soup.

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|---|---|
| 2 tablespoons olive oil | 1 cup coarsely chopped cilantro [250ml] |
| 1 medium red onion, chopped | 6 medium-size tomatoes, seeded and coarsely chopped |
| 4 garlic cloves, minced | 4 cups cooked or canned black beans [650g] |
| 1½ tablespoons whole cumin seeds, crushed | 4 cups vegetable stock [1L] |
| 2 to 3 teaspoons chipotle chile powder,* to taste | 2 ripe but firm avocados, cubed |
| 2 cinnamon sticks | Juice from 1 fresh lime |
| 2 tablespoons unrefined cane sugar | Freshly ground pepper |
| 2 teaspoons salt | |

1. In a large soup pot, **heat** the olive oil over medium heat. Add the red onion and cook, stirring occasionally, until soft, 5 to 7 minutes.
2. **Add** the garlic, cumin seeds, chipotle chile powder, cinnamon sticks, sugar, salt, and ½ cup of the chopped cilantro. Cook, stirring often, 2 to 3 minutes, until the spices are fragrant.
3. Add the tomatoes and beans and cook an additional 2 to 3 minutes. **Pour** in the stock and bring to a boil. Reduce the heat and simmer for 15 to 20 minutes.
4. Remove about 1½ cups [375ml] of the beans with some liquid and **puree** in a blender or food processor. Stir back into the pot.
5. Just before serving, add the avocados, lime juice, and remaining cilantro. **Season** with additional salt and pepper to taste.

SERVES 6 TO 8

*If the powder is unavailable, use ½ to 1 dried chipotle chile soaked in hot water and minced.

Fennel, tomato, and white bean soup

Tomato makes a wonderful, rich base with just enough sweetness to complement the licorice taste of fresh fennel beautifully. Any white bean—cannellini, Great Northern, or navy—will work here. If you can spare the time, let this soup stand for several hours or make it a day ahead, refrigerate, and reheat before serving.

1 large fennel bulb, coarsely chopped, tender leaves reserved for garnish

1 small onion, chopped

6 garlic cloves, thinly sliced

1½ teaspoons salt

¼ teaspoon freshly ground pepper

1½ tablespoons olive oil

1 pound ripe tomatoes, seeded and chopped [500g]

6 cups vegetable stock [1.5L]

3 cups cooked white beans [330g]

1 to 2 tablespoons fresh minced parsley

Splash of white wine vinegar or white wine

1. In a heavy-bottomed soup pot, **sauté** the chopped fennel, onion, garlic, salt, and pepper in the olive oil over medium heat until the vegetables are softened but not browned, about 7 minutes. Add the tomatoes and continue to cook another 2 to 3 minutes.
2. **Pour** in the stock and bring it to boil. Reduce the heat to a simmer and cook for 20 minutes.
3. Stir in the beans and parsley. **Simmer** for another 5 minutes or so. Season with additional salt and pepper to taste. Add the vinegar. Just before serving, garnish with the reserved fennel leaves.

SERVES 6

Savory harira Soup

This Moroccan soup is so rich and delicious, your guests won't be able to get enough of it. Don't let the list of ingredients dissuade you: it's relatively **easy** to prepare, and the results are fabulous.

2 tablespoons olive oil

1 large onion, chopped

1 celery rib, chopped

½ cup minced parsley [125ml]

1 teaspoon turmeric

1 teaspoon salt

1 teaspoon freshly ground pepper

1 teaspoon paprika

1 teaspoon caraway seeds

½ teaspoon cinnamon

½ bay leaf

2 tablespoons chopped cilantro

½ cup dried lentils [100g]

1 can (28 ounces) crushed tomatoes [784g or 825ml]

1 tablespoon tomato paste

6 cups vegetable stock [1.5L]

3 tablespoons unbleached flour mixed to a paste with ½ cup cold water [125ml]

Lemon slices, for garnish

1. In a large soup pot, **heat** the olive oil over medium heat. Add the onion, celery, parsley, turmeric, salt, and pepper. Cook for 5 to 7 minutes, or until the onions are softened but not browned; stir often.
2. **Add** the paprika, caraway seeds, cinnamon, bay leaf, and cilantro and stir for about 15 seconds. Add the lentils, tomatoes, tomato paste, and stock. Bring to a boil. Reduce the heat to a simmer, cover, and cook for 20 minutes, or until the lentils are soft.
3. Just before serving, **whisk** in the flour mixture, blending thoroughly to avoid lumps. Bring to a boil, stirring until slightly thickened. Serve hot, with a slice of lemon in each bowl.

SERVES 8 TO 10

French lentil soup with tarragon and lemon

This recipe calls for French lentils, which are smaller and darker—and hold their shape better—than their larger, greener cousins. It is a rich, **heart**y soup, perfect with sandwiches on a cool afternoon. The lemon juice and tart fresh sorrel garnish add just the right **zing**. On occasion, I've also added fresh tarragon as a garnish, which is another excellent complement to the soup.

1 medium onion, finely chopped

2 garlic cloves, minced

1 celery rib, finely chopped

2 carrots, peeled and cut into ½-inch dice
[1-cm]

1 bay leaf

1 tablespoon dried tarragon

1 teaspoon dried oregano

1 teaspoon salt

⅛ teaspoon freshly ground pepper

2 tablespoons olive oil

1 cup lentils, preferably French [200g]

6 cups vegetable stock or water [1.5L]

2 medium red potatoes, cut into ½-inch dice
[1-cm]

4 to 5 tablespoons fresh lemon juice

Chopped fresh tarragon or shredded sorrel
for garnish

1. In a large pot, **cook** the onion, garlic, celery, carrots, bay leaf, tarragon, oregano, salt, and pepper slowly in the olive oil over medium-low heat until the onion is soft but not brown, 7 to 9 minutes.
2. **Add** the lentils and stock and bring to a boil. Add the potatoes, reduce the heat, and simmer for 40 to 45 minutes, or until lentils are tender but not mushy.
3. Remove the soup from the heat. **Stir** in the lemon juice and season with additional salt and pepper to taste. Ladle the soup into bowls and garnish with tarragon or sorrel.

SERVES 6

Lentil ginger coconut Soup

In my view, you can never have too many lentil soups. Lentils don't need soaking; they cook relatively quickly and work well with many flavor combinations. Lentil soups **taste great** in a light broth or in a thicker, heartier one, as in this soup. If you prefer, add an additional cup of stock for a lighter soup.

1 medium onion, finely chopped

1½ tablespoons olive oil

1 celery rib, finely chopped

1 carrot, peeled and chopped

1 tablespoon minced fresh ginger

1 teaspoon salt

⅛ teaspoon freshly ground pepper

2 tablespoons North African Spice Mix
(page 158)

1½ cups lentils [300g]

1 can (14 ounces) unsweetened coconut milk
[450ml]

4 cups vegetable stock [1L]

1 tablespoon tomato paste

1 tablespoon cider vinegar

1 tablespoon lemon juice

1 teaspoon hot sauce, or to taste

3 tablespoons unsweetened grated coconut

1. In a large soup pot, **cook** the onion in the olive oil over medium heat until very soft and lightly browned, 7 to 10 minutes. Add the celery, carrot, ginger, salt, and pepper. Continue to cook for another 2 minutes.
2. Add the spice mix and cook, **stirring**, 10 to 20 seconds, or until fragrant. Add the lentils, coconut milk, stock, and tomato paste. Cover and bring to a boil. Reduce the heat to a simmer and continue to cook, covered, for 30 to 40 minutes, or until the lentils are soft.
3. Stir in the vinegar, lemon juice, and hot sauce. **Simmer** for another 3 minutes. Season with additional salt and pepper to taste. Garnish the soup with grated coconut.

SERVES 6 TO 8

Pea and potato Soup with smoky tempeh

I love the taste of smoke in pea soup and have found **Smoked tempeh**—packaged as **Fakin' Bacon**—works with excellent results. In addition to the smoky flavor, you get soft crunch of the tempeh squares in the soup. If you can't find smoked tempeh, use plain tempeh, fried until crisp. You can't miss calling this soup a meal in a bowl. Serve with fresh bread and a salad.

2 packages (6 ounces each) Fakin' Bacon
brand smoked tempeh [350g]

3 to 4 tablespoons vegetable oil

1¾ teaspoons salt

1 onion, finely chopped

2 carrots, peeled and finely chopped

3 garlic cloves, minced

4 medium white potatoes, diced

¼ teaspoon freshly ground pepper

2 cups split green peas [400g]

9 cups vegetable stock or water, or more as
needed [2.25L]

1 to 2 tablespoons fresh lemon juice

Fresh mint, thinly sliced for garnish

1. In heavy-bottomed soup pot, **fry** the smoked tempeh strips in 2 tablespoons of the vegetable oil over medium-high heat, turning frequently, until lightly browned and crisp, 2 or 3 minutes per side. Drain on paper towels and season with ¼ teaspoon of the salt, then cut into squares.
2. In the same pot, **sauté** the onion in the remaining oil until soft and lightly browned, about 5 minutes. Add the carrots, garlic, and potatoes and cook for 1 or 2 minutes longer, until the garlic softens and becomes fragrant. Season with the pepper and remaining 1½ teaspoons salt.
3. **Add** the split peas and stock and bring to a boil. Reduce the heat, cover, and simmer for 45 minutes.
4. Stir in the lemon juice and fried tempeh. Cover and **simmer** for 15 minutes longer. Season with additional salt and pepper to taste. Garnish with mint just before serving.

SERVES 8 TO 10

Creamy red lentil chowder

Lentil chowder? Yes, but no corn in this one. I blend red lentils—which actually look orange—with silken tofu and miso to make a lively cream soup. This chowder offers an easy way to add soy to your diet, perfect for those who don't eat dairy.

1 tablespoon olive oil

½ onion, finely chopped

1 carrot, finely chopped

1 celery rib, finely chopped

2 garlic cloves, minced

1 bay leaf

2 teaspoons dried oregano

2 teaspoons dried basil

1 cinnamon stick

1 teaspoon salt

¼ teaspoon freshly ground pepper

1 large tomato, cut into medium dice

1½ cups red lentils [300g]

5 cups vegetable stock or water [1.25L]

1 cup dry white wine [250ml]

6 ounces silken tofu [180g]

1 tablespoon chickpea miso or white miso

2 tablespoons fresh lemon juice

1 tablespoon cider vinegar

Splash of hot sauce

1. In a heavy-bottomed soup pot, **heat** the olive oil over medium-low heat. Add the onion and cook until slightly softened, about 3 minutes. Add the carrot and celery and continue to cook for another few minutes until the vegetables soften. Add the garlic, bay leaf, oregano, basil, and cinnamon stick. Sauté for 1 to 2 minutes, stirring often, until the garlic is fragrant. Season with the salt and pepper.
2. Add the tomato and cook for 1 minute. **Stir** in the lentils, stock, and wine. Cover and bring to a boil. Reduce to a simmer and cook, partially covered, for 15 to 20 minutes, or until the lentils are soft. Remove and discard the bay leaf and cinnamon stick.
3. Put the tofu, miso, and 2 cups of the soup in a blender or food processor. **Puree** until very well mixed. Stir into the rest of the soup in the pot. Add the lemon juice, vinegar, and hot sauce. Season with additional salt and pepper to taste.

SERVES 8 TO 10

Corn tempeh chowder

Oats and soy milk make this soup **creamy** without the addition of dairy products. The dried mushrooms, arame, and grated tempeh provide a hint of both earth and sea, which gives this soup a comforting, chowder-like taste.

½ ounce dried mushrooms (chanterelle, shiitake, or mixed) [15g]

3 tablespoons arame sea vegetable

1 medium onion, chopped

2 celery ribs, finely chopped, leaves reserved for garnish

2 tablespoons olive oil

1 package (8 ounces) tempeh, grated [250g]

Salt and freshly ground pepper

3 cups fresh or frozen corn kernels [375g]

4 cups plain soy milk [1L]

½ cup rolled oats [50g]

2 cups vegetable stock or water [.5L]

1 tablespoon chickpea miso or white miso

1. In a small bowl, **soak** the dried mushrooms and arame in enough hot water to cover. Cover the bowl and set it aside until the vegetables are softened, about 30 minutes. Drain, reserving the soaking water. Coarsely chop both the mushrooms and the arame. Strain the soaking water through a paper coffee filter and set it aside.
2. In a heavy-bottomed soup pot, **cook** the onion and celery in the olive oil over medium heat until the onion is soft and translucent, about 5 minutes. Add the grated tempeh and cook for 2 minutes longer, stirring frequently. Season lightly with salt and pepper.
3. **Stir** in the corn and chopped mushrooms and arame. Add the soy milk and reserved soaking water and bring to a simmer. In the meantime, puree the oats with the vegetable stock in a blender or food processor. Stir into the soup and simmer, partially covered, for 30 minutes. Stir often, as oats tend to stick.
4. In a small bowl, **blend** the miso with a small amount of the soup until well mixed. Stir into the rest of the soup in the pot. Season generously with salt and pepper. Garnish with celery leaves when serving.

SERVES 8 TO 10

Barley mushroom seitan Soup

We look at barley today and see a simple, hearty, and nutritious grain. Yet, a look back reveals a **fascinating** history. It has been revered for thousands of years by virtually all the great civilizations, from the Hebrews, Greeks, and Romans, to the Hindus and Chinese. It's been used for currency in all kinds of rites and celebrations, and as training food for athletes. Traditional mushroom barley soup has a deep, dark, meaty base. My healthful vegetarian version uses lots of tomato and chunks of seitan to produce a hearty, nutritious broth.

2 tablespoons olive oil

1 medium onion, finely chopped	½ pound prepared seitan, cut into ½-inch [1-cm] chunks [250g]
1 celery rib, finely chopped	1½ teaspoons salt
1 large carrot, peeled and finely chopped	¼ teaspoon freshly ground pepper
1 parsnip, peeled and finely chopped	5 cups vegetable stock or water [1.25L]
2 teaspoons dill seeds, crushed in a mortar and pestle	2 cups crushed tomatoes [500ml]
2 garlic cloves, minced	1 cup hulled barley [180g]
½ pound cremini mushrooms, thinly sliced [250g]	2 tablespoons coarsely chopped fresh dill

1. In a soup pot, **heat** the olive oil over medium heat. Add the onion, celery, carrot, and parsnip. Cook, stirring occasionally, until soft, 7 to 10 minutes.
2. **Add** the dill seeds, garlic, and mushrooms. Continue to cook until the mushrooms are tender and lightly browned, 5 to 7 minutes.
3. **Stir** in the seitan and season with the salt and pepper. Add the stock, tomatoes, and barley; bring to a boil. Reduce the heat and simmer, stirring occasionally, for 1½ hours, or until the barley is tender. Stir in the dill just before serving.

SERVES 10 TO 12

Chilled summer fruit soup with berry- wine swirl

I was never a big fan of chilled soup until I made this one. The Berry-Wine Swirl brings alive an already **luscious** soup. What a great way to start a summer lunch or end light supper on a hot summer evening. Use the freshest, sweetest fruit you can find.

1 medium cantaloupe—seeded, rind removed, melon coarsely chopped

1 peach—skinned, pitted, and coarsely chopped

1 mango—skinned, seeded, and coarsely chopped

2 to 3 tablespoons honey

Juice of 1 large orange

Juice of 1 lime

Pinch of salt

Berry-Wine Swirl (recipe below)

1. In a blender or food processor, **combine** all the ingredients except the Berry-Wine Swirl. Puree until smooth. Transfer to a bowl, cover, and refrigerate until well chilled, at least 2 hours.
2. **Ladle** the cold soup into bowls. Drizzle Berry-Wine Swirl on top, decorating the soup with Jackson Pollock squiggles or Zen-like swirls.

SERVES 4

Berry-wine swirl

1 tablespoon minced fresh ginger

½ cup blueberries [65g]

1 teaspoon tamarind paste

¼ cup dry red wine [60ml]

2½ tablespoons maple syrup

Splash of red wine vinegar

Puree all the ingredients in a blender or food processor. Adjust the sweetness or tartness to reach desired taste.

MAKES ABOUT ¼ CUP (60ML)

Cinnamon polenta porridge with bananas and almonds

Often overlooked, polenta is a **great** meal idea for breakfast. Embellish with strawberries, apples, and/or melted butter if you like.

2 cups vanilla rice milk or soy milk [500ml]

3 cups water [750ml]

2 tablespoons maple syrup

½ teaspoon salt

1 cup coarsely ground polenta [125g]

2 bananas, sliced into rounds

¼ cup honey [100g]

½ cup slivered blanched almonds, toasted*
[40g]

1 to 2 teaspoons ground cinnamon

1. In a heavy saucepan, **combine** the milk, water, maple syrup, and salt. Bring to a boil over medium heat.
2. **Drizzle** the polenta into the pot in a slow, thin stream, stirring as you add it. Whisk constantly until all the grains have been absorbed. Reduce the heat to medium-low.
3. Switch to a wooden spatula and continue to cook, **stirring**, for 15 to 20 minutes, until the polenta is very creamy and pulls away from the sides of the pot. Add more milk or water if the mixture becomes too thick.
4. Ladle the polenta into bowls. **Top** with bananas, honey, almonds, and cinnamon.

SERVES 6

* To toast almonds, preheat the oven to 300°F [150°C]. Place almonds on a baking sheet and toast for 7 to 10 minutes, watching carefully so they don't burn. Mix and move them around every few minutes until they start to brown slightly.

Oatmeal with dried cherries, apples, and nuts

Okay, I admit, this recipe has many **health** benefits. It's loaded with protein, fiber, vitamins, and minerals. But who can complain about starting the day with such abundance. This oatmeal is very **thick** and porridgy—the way I like it. If you prefer a softer consistency, add more liquid.

1½ cups plain or vanilla rice milk [375ml]

¼ cup apple juice [60ml]

¼ teaspoon salt

1 cinnamon stick

¾ cup rolled thick-cut rolled oats [70g]

3 tablespoons dried cherries

2 teaspoons sliced almonds

1 teaspoon flax seeds

1 teaspoon brown or white sesame seeds

1 teaspoon raw, hulled sunflower seeds

½ tart apple, seeded and finely diced

1 tablespoon maple syrup

½ teaspoon vanilla extract

1. In a large saucepan, **combine** the milk, apple juice, salt, and cinnamon stick. Bring to a boil.
2. Add the rolled oats and reduce the heat to a bare simmer. **Cook**, stirring often to prevent sticking, for 10 minutes, or until the oats are as soft as you desire.
3. **Stir** in the dried cherries, almonds, flax seeds, sesame seeds, sunflower seeds, apple, maple syrup, and vanilla. If the cereal is too thick, add more milk; if too loose, cook for another 1 to 2 minutes.
4. Remove from the heat, **cover**, and let the oatmeal stand for 5 minutes before serving.

SERVES 2

The ultimate tofu scramble

A tasty dish with zing and a mysterious resemblance to scrambled eggs, this **vegan delight** is the real deal when it comes to tofu scrambles—don't accept substitutes. It is excellent topped with fresh salsa or Worcestershire sauce. Add dried or fresh herbs, or substitute chipotle or regular chile powder for the mustard to spice up the scramble.

2 tablespoons yellow miso or chickpea miso

½ teaspoon turmeric

2 teaspoons yellow powdered mustard

Dash of wasabi powder (optional)

1 tablespoon nutritional yeast

1 teaspoon salt

¼ teaspoon freshly ground pepper

⅓ cup vegetable stock or water [75ml]

1 pound firm or soft (not silken) tofu, drained and pressed of water [500g]

2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

3 medium shallots or ½ onion, finely chopped

1 red bell pepper, diced

2 tablespoons chopped chives or scallions

Salsa or vegetarian Worcestershire sauce

1. In a medium bowl, **combine** the miso, turmeric, powdered mustard, wasabi, yeast, salt, pepper, and stock. Mix to a smooth paste.
2. **Crumble** the tofu into the miso mixture and blend well. Add 1 tablespoon of the olive oil and mix again until very well incorporated. Set aside.
3. In a medium skillet, preferably nonstick, **cook** the shallots in the remaining oil over medium heat until softened, 2 to 3 minutes. Add the red pepper and sauté an additional 1 to 2 minutes.
4. Add the tofu mixture and cook, **stirring** constantly, until the tofu is just heated through and the shallots and bell pepper are mixed in. Remove from the heat. Garnish with chives and top with salsa or Worcestershire sauce.

MAKES 2 LARGE OR 3 MEDIUM-SIZE PORTIONS

Sun lake scrambled eggs

Interesting ingredients make these eggs uncommonly good. This recipe, born on a camping trip over an open fire and then refined in the kitchen, still makes good use of the **cast-iron** skillet. The use and quantity of the jalapeño pepper depends on your love of heat.

1 to 2 jalapeño peppers, seeds and ribs removed, sliced lengthwise in quarters or eighths

8 free-range eggs

¼ cup plain soy milk or dairy milk [60ml]

Juice of ½ lime

1 tablespoon maple syrup

1 tablespoon soy sauce

2 to 3 drops of hot pepper oil (optional)

½ teaspoon salt

⅛ teaspoon freshly ground pepper

2 teaspoons olive oil

1 small red bell pepper, cut into thick strips

6 ounces shiitake mushrooms, stemmed, caps thinly sliced [180g]

2 to 3 tablespoons feta cheese

Shredded fresh basil leaves, for garnish

1. In a small, very hot dry skillet, **cook** the jalapeño peppers until blistered and slightly withered. Remove to a plate.
2. **Heat** half of the olive oil in a large nonstick or well-seasoned cast-iron skillet. Add the red bell pepper and cook over medium-high heat until softened, 2 to 3 minutes. Remove with tongs or a slotted spoon and add to the jalapeño peppers on the plate.
3. Add the mushrooms to the skillet and cook until tender and lightly browned, 3 to 5 minutes. **Add** to the other vegetables.
4. In a medium bowl, **beat** the eggs with the milk, lime juice, maple syrup, soy sauce, hot oil, salt, and pepper. Heat the remaining olive oil in the skillet, add the egg mixture, and reduce the heat to medium. As the eggs start to set, move them with a wooden spoon, repeating as they set again. Just before they are done to a medium firmness, add the vegetables and fold over to mix the ingredients. Add the feta cheese just as the desired firmness is achieved. Top with basil and serve at once, right from the skillet.

SERVES 4

Herbed potatoes, corn, and zucchini

Herbed potatoes make a good side dish for almost any breakfast, but of course they work especially well with eggs. Sometimes I am reluctant to use the word *healthy*, even though it might be true of some of my recipes. I think it's overused and too subjectively understood, but what the hay—let's call this dish a **healthy** version of hash browns. There. I said it. And they taste good, too.

4 small red potatoes, 1½ to 2 inches in diameter [4 to 5cm]

½ medium onion, finely chopped

1 tablespoon vegetable oil

1 teaspoon dried fennel seeds

1 teaspoon dried thyme

1 teaspoon dried basil

1 cup fresh or frozen corn kernels [120g]

½ medium zucchini, cut lengthwise in half and sliced crosswise ¼ inch thick [.5cm]

Salt and freshly ground pepper

Extra virgin olive oil

1. **Cut** the potatoes into eighths and steam or boil them until tender but still firm.
2. In a hot wok or large skillet, **cook** the onion in the vegetable oil over medium-high heat until soft and lightly browned, about 5 minutes. Season with the fennel seeds, thyme, and basil and cook, tossing, for 15 to 30 seconds.
3. Add the potatoes and stir until they are well coated with onions and herbs. **Add** the corn and then the zucchini. Cook for 2 to 3 minutes, or until the vegetables are crisp-tender. Season generously with salt and pepper and drizzle with olive oil.

SERVES 4 TO 6

Maple-glazed potatoes with garlic and soy sauce

Sweet and savory potatoes, lightly **crisped** in a very hot oven, are soul-satisfying. Serve with spicy eggs and a salad.

8 medium-size red potatoes, scrubbed and sliced into eighths

1½ tablespoons olive oil

Salt and freshly ground black pepper

¼ cup maple syrup [60ml]

2 teaspoons soy sauce

2 garlic cloves, minced

½ teaspoon crushed hot red pepper

1. **Preheat** the oven to 450°F [230°C]. In a large bowl, toss the potatoes with the olive oil and salt and black pepper to taste. Transfer to a baking dish, tent with foil, and roast for 15 minutes. Set the used bowl aside.
2. Meanwhile, in a small bowl, **stir** together the maple syrup, soy sauce, and garlic.
3. After 15 minutes, **remove** the roasted potatoes from the oven and spoon them back into the same large bowl. Pour in half of the maple syrup mixture. Toss to coat the potatoes well. Return them to the baking dish and bake, uncovered, for 10 minutes.
4. Remove the potatoes from the oven and return them to the bowl. **Add** the remaining maple syrup mixture plus the hot pepper and toss to coat well. Season again with salt and black pepper and return to the oven for 10 minutes longer, or until the potatoes are browned and lightly crisped.

SERVES 4

Roasted pear sandwich with walnut pesto

Pears and walnuts are a classic duo, more familiar in salads than between two slices of bread. This gourmet sandwich offers a variety of **contrasting** tastes and textures: sweet and savory, soft and crunchy. There's plenty of room to improvise with your own additions, if you like. I add roasted red bell peppers to mine. You could use a different-flavored pesto or spread or substitute an apple for the pear.

1 firm ripe pear, halved lengthwise, cored and cut lengthwise into slices about ¼ inch [.5cm] thick

1 teaspoon olive oil

3 tablespoons Walnut Pesto (recipe follows)

4 slices of whole-grain bread, toasted

6 slices of smoked or regular mozzarella cheese

4 leaves of crisp lettuce

Roasted red bell peppers, cut into strips (optional)

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1. **Preheat** the oven to 400°F [200°C]. Lightly coat the pear slices with the olive oil. Spread out in a single layer in a small baking dish and roast for 20 minutes, or until softened and lightly browned.
2. Spread the pesto on one side of each slice of toast. **Layer** the remaining ingredients on half the slices and season with salt and pepper to taste. Sandwich with the second slice of bread, pesto side down, and press down firmly. Serve at once or wrap tightly in plastic and refrigerate for up to 3 hours.

MAKES 2 SANDWICHES

Walnut pesto

¼ cup walnut pieces [75g]

3 garlic cloves

¼ cup coarsely chopped parsley [60ml]

¼ cup extra virgin olive oil [60ml]

1 tablespoon lemon juice

2 teaspoons maple syrup

Salt and freshly ground pepper

In a food processor, **combine** the walnuts, garlic, parsley, olive oil, lemon juice, and maple syrup. Puree to a paste. Season with salt and pepper to taste. Set aside for at least 1 hour before serving.

MAKES ABOUT 1 CUP [250ML]

Sun-dried tomato pesto

If you are old fashioned or just prefer using a little muscle, use a large marble mortar and pestle to prepare this rather than a food processor. Start by grinding the sun-dried tomatoes and move on down the list until you get a nice thick paste. Slowly add the oil and lemon juice and season with salt and pepper.

1 ounce sun-dried tomatoes, soaked in hot water until soft, chopped [30g]

1 roasted red pepper, coarsely chopped

3 garlic cloves, coarsely chopped

2 tablespoons pine nuts

¼ cup coarsely chopped fresh basil [60ml]

2 tablespoons nutritional yeast

1 teaspoon paprika

2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

2 tablespoons lemon juice

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1. In food processor, **pulse** the sun-dried tomatoes, roasted pepper, garlic, pine nuts, basil, yeast, and paprika until a thick, chunky paste forms.
2. Add the olive oil and lemon juice and pulse again once or twice. **Season** with salt and pepper to taste. Set aside for at least 1 hour before serving.

MAKES ABOUT 1 CUP [250ML]

Hummus, Jarlsburg, and roasted hot pepper sandwich

Garlic from the hummus, a bite from the pepper, and a smoky, savory sensation from the cheese work beautifully together to create what is possibly one of the greatest vegetarian sandwiches I have ever tasted. Yes, I know that's a **bold** statement, but most chefs love their own cooking, so what can I say?

Fresh cayenne peppers are **exquisite**, one of those ingredients worth going out of your way to find. Many large gourmet supermarkets or small Mexican or Asian markets will have a variety of peppers during the season. If you cannot find a fresh cayenne, substitute another hot pepper, such as a serrano or jalapeño. If you prefer milder food, use a roasted red bell pepper.

2 tablespoons Roasted Pepper Hummus
(page 20)

2 slices of whole grain bread, toasted

Store-bought or homemade seitan slices (see
page 230)

2 slices of roasted cayenne, serrano, or other
hot pepper

½ avocado, sliced

2 slices of Jarlsburg cheese

4 or 5 thinly sliced cucumber rounds

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1 teaspoon extra virgin olive oil

1. **Spread** the hummus over one side of both pieces of toast.
2. On one slice, layer the seitan, roasted hot pepper, avocado, Jarlsburg cheese, and cucumber rounds. Season lightly with salt and pepper. **Drizzle** the olive oil over the cucumbers.
3. Top with the remaining slice of toast, hummus side down. **Press** down firmly and cut in half.

MAKES 1 SANDWICH

Russian dressing with sun-dried tomatoes

This dressing is especially thick—a bold dressing for a hearty salad of greens and tomatoes. It also doubles beautifully as a spread over tempeh and sauerkraut for a Reuben sandwich. Add more soaking liquid if you prefer a thinner dressing.

4 ounces silken tofu [125g]

1 tablespoon ketchup

2 teaspoons bottled plain (not creamed) horseradish (red or white)

1 small shallot, minced

5 sun-dried tomatoes soaked in 1 cup [250ml] hot water until soft, coarsely chopped, soaking liquid reserved

1 teaspoon vegetarian Worcestershire sauce

½ teaspoon salt

Pinch of freshly ground pepper

Mix all the ingredients in a blender, gradually adding the reserved tomato soaking liquid (anywhere from 2 to 4 tablespoons) until the dressing reaches the desired thickness. Scrape down the sides of the blender two or three times until the dressing is very well mixed. Adjust seasoning, if necessary. Let stand at least 1 hour before serving.

MAKES ABOUT ½ CUP [125ML]

Tempeh-mushroom Joe

To my mind, there's no Joe like a tempeh Joe. Trying to get your children to eat soy may be difficult, but not with this dish. They'll **enjoy** it just as they would a meat-based sloppy Joe—and chances are they won't notice the difference. By the way, you'll like it, too. As a change, consider **ladling the savory topping over spaghetti or linguine instead of buns.**

1 medium onion, chopped
2 tablespoons canola or olive oil
3 garlic cloves, minced
½ pound cremini or white button mushrooms, thinly sliced [250g]
½ green bell pepper, chopped
½ red bell pepper, chopped
8 ounces tempeh, shredded or crumbled [250g]
1 teaspoon salt

¼ teaspoon freshly ground pepper
1 can (28 ounces) crushed tomatoes [875ml]
1 tablespoon unrefined cane sugar or honey
1 tablespoon vegetarian Worcestershire sauce
2 tablespoons tomato paste
1½ tablespoons cider vinegar
8 hamburger buns

1. In a large skillet, **cook** the onion in the olive oil over medium heat until very soft, about 5 minutes. Add the garlic, mushrooms, green and red peppers, and tempeh. Season with the salt and pepper. Cook until the vegetables are softened, stirring several times, 5 to 7 minutes longer.
2. Add the crushed tomatoes. Bring to a boil. **Stir** in the sugar or honey, Worcestershire sauce, tomato paste, and vinegar. Reduce the heat to medium-low and simmer for 5 to 10 minutes. Serve hot between split hamburger buns.

SERVES 8

Red pepper chipotle cream

This is a multipurpose topping for almost any burger or fritter. It also makes a great dressing for a crunchy salad and a fine sauce for Cajun Tempeh (page 146).

NOTE As with many tofu spreads, the possible alternatives here are infinite. Substitute sun-dried tomatoes or prepared sun-dried tomato pesto for the red pepper. Or try cilantro, lime, or pesto as flavor ingredients.

1 dried chipotle chile	1 teaspoon ground cumin
2 garlic cloves, minced	½ teaspoon paprika
1 red bell pepper, roasted and coarsely chopped	2 teaspoons red wine vinegar or sherry vinegar
8 to 10 ounces silken tofu [250 to 300g]	1 teaspoon maple syrup
1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil	Salt

1. Start a kettle of hot water boiling. Remove the stem from the chipotle chile. **Crack** open the chile and remove the majority of the seeds. Soak the chile in about 2 cups [500ml] of the boiling water until soft. Drain and finely chop or mince.
2. Puree the garlic, bell pepper, and chile in a food processor until very smooth, scraping down the sides once or twice. **Add** the tofu and blend well again. With the machine on, add the olive oil, cumin, paprika, vinegar, and maple syrup, processing until very smooth and creamy. Season with salt to taste.
3. Cover and **refrigerate** 2 hours or overnight.

MAKES ABOUT 1 CUP [250ML]

Spicy yogurt sauce

The technique of making “cheese” out of yogurt is quite appealing. It thickens the yogurt and concentrates the flavors. Use as a dip or topping or even as a side dish. At parties I’ve watched people who stand by the table and keep eating it until it’s all gone. It’s perfect as a sauce for the Lentil Scallion Fritters that follow. Other ideas for using Spicy Yogurt Sauce include as a topping for Curried Corn Burgers (page 102), or as a dip for Pita Chips (page 34).

3 cups plain yogurt, preferably organic
[750ml]

1 cup sour cream, preferably organic [250ml]

3 tablespoons crushed peanuts

3 garlic cloves, minced

1 small red onion, finely chopped

1 or 2 fresh serrano pepper, minced

Salt

½ cup unrefined cane sugar [100g]

1½ teaspoons ground cumin

1. **Line** a fine mesh strainer with a double layer of cheesecloth, using enough cloth so that it hangs over the sides. Set the strainer over a bowl so there is 1 to 2 inches [3 to 5cm] of space between the bottom of strainer and the bottom of bowl. Pour the yogurt into the strainer and cover it with plastic wrap or a plate. Refrigerate overnight.
2. When done, the yogurt should be very thick, like sour cream. Discard the water in the bowl. Place the thickened yogurt and remaining ingredients in a clean bowl. **Add** the peanuts, garlic, red onion, serrano peppers, sugar, and cumin. Fold to mix well. Season with salt to taste. Let stand for about 1 hour to allow flavors to develop. Serve cool or at room temperature.

MAKES ABOUT 3 CUPS [750ML]

Amazing tofu teriyaki

If you like teriyaki, you'll love this dish. The sugar gives it a nice gloss, and the flavor is intense. This very easy recipe makes use of the quick version of marinating tofu. It also works well with frozen tofu.

3 tablespoons sherry vinegar
2 tablespoons toasted sesame oil
2 tablespoons mirin
1 tablespoon soy sauce
2 tablespoons unrefined cane sugar

4 to 5 dashes of Tabasco sauce
1 tablespoon minced fresh ginger
Freshly ground pepper
¼ cup vegetable oil [60ml]
1 pound extra-firm tofu, sliced in half or thirds lengthwise [500g]

1. In a small bowl, **combine** the vinegar, sesame oil, mirin, soy sauce, sugar, Tabasco, ginger, and a light grinding of pepper. Stir to mix well.
2. In a large cast-iron skillet or heavy-duty frying pan, **heat** the vegetable oil over medium-high heat. When the oil is very hot and almost shimmering, fry the tofu, turning once, until lightly browned and crisp on both sides, 3 to 5 minutes. Drain on paper towels. Pour out excess oil from the pan and set aside.
3. While the tofu is still warm, **cut** it into cubes. Add the marinade and mix until very well coated. Set aside until ready to finish them off in the skillet. If you have the time, let the tofu marinate for 30 to 60 minutes.
4. Increase the heat to high. When the skillet is very hot, **pour** the marinated tofu and all the marinade back into the pan. (Use a rubber spatula to scrape all the marinade out of the bowl.) Fry, stirring constantly, until the marinade is completely absorbed and the tofu is well coated.

SERVES 2

Soft tofu tacos with tomatillo pumpkin seed sauce

A slightly spicy, wonderfully tart tomatillo sauce pairs with **crunchy** tofu to produce a traditional Mexican specialty you'll make over and over. Start with one of my guacamole recipes and serve Red Chile Roasted Tomato Rice (page 270) on the side. I highly recommend ice-cold beer to wash it all down.

NOTE For this recipe you will need two pieces of equipment: a spice grinder and a steamer large enough to accommodate the tortillas.

¼ cup vegetable stock [60ml]

1 tablespoon olive oil

1 tablespoon sherry vinegar

1 tablespoon unrefined cane sugar

½ teaspoon salt

Freshly ground pepper

¼ cup vegetable oil, for frying [60ml]

1 pound extra-firm tofu, pressed to remove excess water, sliced in half [500g]

6 corn tortillas, steamed until soft

Tomatillo Pumpkin Seed Sauce (recipe follows)

1. In a medium bowl, **mix** together the vegetable stock, olive oil, vinegar, sugar, salt, and a generous grinding of pepper. Set the marinade aside.
2. In a large cast-iron skillet, **heat** the vegetable oil over medium-high heat until very hot and almost shimmering. Add the tofu and fry, turning once, until lightly browned and crisp on both sides, 3 to 4 minutes. Drain on paper towels. As soon as the tofu is cool enough to handle, cut it into thin strips 2 inches [5cm] long and add to the marinade. Stir gently until very well coated.
3. **Pour** out most of the oil from the skillet. Heat the skillet over medium-high heat. Pour the tofu strips with their marinade into the pan. Cook, stirring constantly, until the marinade is completely absorbed and the tofu is glazed with sauce.

5. Form each taco by placing tofu strips in the center of a tortilla. Spoon warm tomatillo pumpkin seed sauce over the tofu, and roll up the tortilla. **Serve** at once.

MAKES 6 TACOS (SERVES 2 OR 3)

Tomatillo pumpkin seed sauce

¼ cup raw pumpkin seeds [35g]

10 tomatillos (about ¾ pound), husked and rinsed [375g]

2 fresh serrano peppers

1½ tablespoons olive oil

1 small white onion, chopped

2 garlic cloves, minced

1 tablespoon unrefined cane sugar

½ cup vegetable stock [125ml]

Salt

1. **Preheat** the broiler with the rack set 4 to 5 inches [10 to 13cm] from the heat. In a hot dry skillet, toast the pumpkin seeds until they plump, 30 to 60 seconds. Let cool, then grind them to a powder in a spice grinder or mini food processor.
2. Put the tomatillos and serrano peppers on a baking sheet and **broil**, turning with tongs, until they are softened and their skins are lightly charred all over, 9 to 12 minutes. As soon as the tomatillos are cool enough to handle, coarsely chop them—skin and all—and set aside in a bowl along with their juices. Remove the stems and seeds from the serrano peppers, coarsely chop them, and add to the tomatillos.
3. In a large cast-iron skillet, **heat** the olive oil over medium heat. Add the onion and cook, stirring occasionally, until softened and lightly browned, 7 to 9 minutes. Add the garlic and cook for another minute.
4. In a blender or food processor, **combine** the tomatillos, peppers, onion, garlic, sugar, and pumpkin seed powder. Puree until smooth. Add 1 to 2 tablespoons vegetable stock or water if the mixture is not blending.
5. For a creamy smooth sauce, **press** through a mesh strainer with a rubber spatula or pass through a food mill into a medium saucepan. Bring to a boil and add the stock. Return to a simmer and cook for 15 to 20 minutes, uncovered, stirring frequently. Season with salt to taste.

MAKES ABOUT 1 ½ CUPS [375ML]

Sweet and hot garlic chili paste

There's just something about making your own chili paste that's so satisfying. This is a good quick one for a stir-fry or any other dish you would like to spice up. If you want, make a big batch, seal it tightly in a covered container, and refrigerate. There are many chili pastes on the market; some are very good, but some have preservatives, and Thai and Vietnamese varieties are sometimes flavored with anchovy and/or shrimp.

8 garlic cloves, finely chopped

1½ tablespoons tamarind paste

2½ tablespoons crushed hot red pepper

2 teaspoons red miso

1½ tablespoons unrefined cane sugar

About 1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil

1. **Crush** or pulse the garlic, hot pepper, and sugar into a paste. For authenticity's sake, a stone mortar and pestle or a *suribachi*, a ribbed ceramic Japanese bowl with a wooden pestle, offer the best results for this recipe (see page 13). If you don't have one, pulse in a food processor—a mini one, if available.
2. Add the tamarind paste and miso and **mix** until well blended. Gradually stir in enough olive oil, a few drops at a time, to make a thick paste. Store the chili paste in a covered jar in the refrigerator. It will keep well for up to 2 weeks.

MAKES ABOUT ½ CUP [125 ML]

Crisp tempeh with mango and hot pepper

This is at once an outrageous, delightful, **simple**, and colorful dish. The beauty of fruit and hot peppers is how well they work together; the punch of the generally common jalapeño or even serrano chile is tamed when matched with the tender sweetness of the mango. Some of the heat is retained, of course, but some dissipates, leaving the dish to shine with color and gusto.

¼ cup vegetable oil [60ml]

1 package (8 ounces) tempeh, cut into 10 strips [250g]

Salt

1 medium onion, coarsely chopped

2 mangoes, peeled and cut into ½-inch [1-cm] dice

1 to 2 fresh jalapeño or serrano peppers, cut into very thin strips

3 tablespoons dry white wine

2 tablespoons plus ½ teaspoon unrefined cane sugar

1 tablespoon peach or red wine vinegar

Freshly ground pepper

2 tablespoons coarsely chopped cilantro

1. In a large skillet, **heat** the vegetable oil over medium-high. When the oil is very hot, add the tempeh strips and fry on both sides until lightly browned, about 2 to 3 minutes. Drain on paper towels, sprinkle lightly with salt, and set aside.
2. **Pour** all but 1 tablespoon of the oil from the pan. Add the onion to the skillet and cook, stirring often, until soft and nicely browned, about 7 to 10 minutes. Add the mangoes and hot peppers. Cook until the fruit is very soft, 3 to 5 minutes. Increase the heat slightly and add the wine. Boil until the wine is reduced by about two-thirds. Stir in the sugar and cook for an additional 30 seconds or so, until completely dissolved.
3. Top the tempeh strips with the fruit sauce. **Splash** with the vinegar, season with pepper, to taste, and garnish with the chopped cilantro.

SERVES 2

Simple tofu sour cream

½ pound firm tofu [250g]

2 teaspoons nutritional yeast

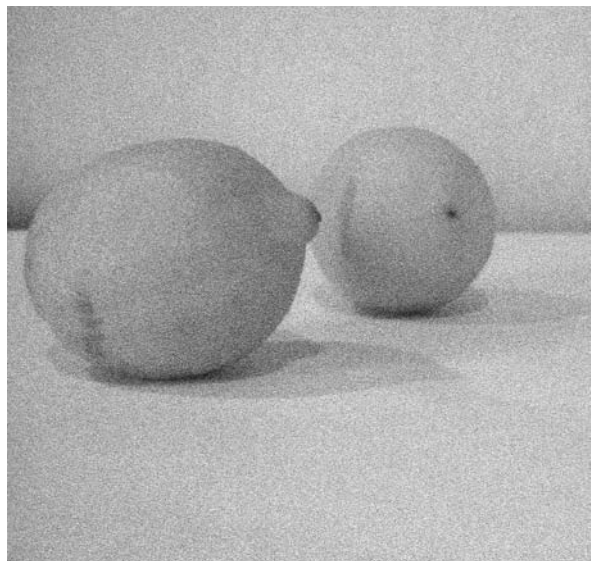
3 tablespoons fresh lemon juice

1 teaspoon brown rice vinegar

2 tablespoons flavorless vegetable oil, such as safflower or grapeseed

1. **Drain** the tofu and press to remove as much water as possible (If you are not familiar with this technique, see page 115).
2. Place the tofu in a blender or food processor with all the remaining ingredients and blend until completely pureed and very well incorporated, at least 2 minutes. **Scrape** down the sides 2 or 3 times.
3. When the “cream” is very smooth, place it in a bowl, cover, and **refrigerate** until chilled. For best results, let chill at least 2 hours or overnight before using.

MAKES ABOUT 1 CUP [250ML]



Thai tempeh red curry

In the old days, canned soups were available in limited flavors. These days, a wide variety of better-quality soups are now available in aseptic containers. The variety and taste level of packaged soups has improved considerably. For this recipe, the best choice is butternut squash soup, which adds a delicate color and **substantial** flavor. Corn or potato leek soup could also be used, or a canned cream soup, if you cannot find butternut. Serve with quinoa or rice.

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1 small onion, chopped | 1 can (15 ounces) unsweetened coconut milk [500ml] |
| 1 tablespoon vegetable oil | 4 medium-size red potatoes, peeled and cut into ½-inch [1-cm] dice |
| 8 fresh shiitake mushrooms, stemmed, caps thinly sliced | 1 package (8 ounces) tempeh, cut into ¾-inch [1-cm] cubes [250g] |
| 1 small red bell pepper, coarsely chopped | 1 can (15 ounces) baby corn [240g] |
| ¾ teaspoon salt | 1 small crisp apple, cut into ½-inch [1-cm] dice |
| Freshly ground pepper | 1 tablespoon soy sauce |
| 1 cup butternut squash soup [250ml] | 2 tablespoons shredded fresh basil, preferably Thai |
| 1 teaspoon Thai red curry paste | |
| 1 tablespoon unrefined cane sugar | |

1. In a large Dutch oven, **cook** the onion in the oil over medium heat until very soft but not brown, 3 to 5 minutes. Add the mushrooms and bell pepper; season with the salt and a grinding of pepper. Cook, stirring often, for 3 to 5 minutes, until slightly softened.
2. In a small bowl, create a wet paste by stirring together 3 tablespoons of the squash soup with the curry paste and sugar. **Stir** into the remaining soup and add to the pan. Stir in the coconut milk. Add the potatoes and tempeh and bring to a boil. Cover, reduce the heat to a simmer, and cook for 20 to 30 minutes, until the potatoes are tender. Stir occasionally to prevent the ingredients from sticking to the bottom of the pot.
3. Add the corn, apple, and soy sauce. **Simmer** for 2 minutes longer to heat through. Serve garnished with fresh basil.

SERVES 4

Adzuki bean and butternut squash stew

Many people are not familiar with adzuki beans, though they are popular in Chinese and Japanese cooking. Adzuki beans are quick cooking and extremely nutritious, and they have a more distinctive, somewhat nuttier taste than most beans. They make a good substitute for lentils in soups, salads, and stews. Serve this recipe with brown or wild rice.

½ to ¾ cup vegetable stock [125 to 200ml]

1 tablespoon minced fresh ginger

1 tablespoon soy sauce

1 tablespoon toasted sesame oil

1 small butternut squash, peeled, seeded, and cut into small chunks

2 cans (15 ounces each) [850g total] adzuki beans, drained, or 1 cup [180g] dried adzuki beans, soaked, and cooked until tender

1 tablespoon red miso or barley miso

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1. In a large pot or saucepan, bring the stock, ginger, soy sauce, and sesame oil to a **simmer**. Add the squash and cook, covered, for 10 to 15 minutes, or until the squash is soft.
2. Add the beans and mix well, continuing to cook for another 2 to 3 minutes. **Stir** in the miso and season with salt and pepper, if it's needed. Add additional stock if the stew becomes too dry.

SERVES 4 TO 6

Almond coconut dal

Lentils are high in protein, fiber, and complex carbohydrates. They also provide an **excellent** source of folic acid. By the way, did you know that in the Old Testament, Esau sold his birthright for a pot of lentils? Needless to say, you don't have to go that far; just enjoy them. Serve with warm pitas, as salad, and with Roasted Root Vegetables (page 257).

1½ tablespoons olive oil

10 fresh chanterelle or shiitake mushrooms,
thinly sliced

2 large shallots, coarsely chopped

¼ teaspoon salt

Freshly ground pepper

1 cup dried lentils [200g]

1 can (15 ounces) unsweetened coconut milk
[450ml]

2½ cups vegetable stock or water [675ml]

2 tablespoons almond butter

2 tablespoons tomato paste

Hot sauce

1. In a large heavy saucepan or Dutch oven, **heat** the olive oil over medium heat. Add the mushrooms and shallots and cook until the mushrooms are tender, about 5 minutes. Season with the salt and a generous grinding of pepper.
2. **Add** the lentils, half the coconut milk, and 2 cups [375ml] of the stock. Cover, bring to a boil, and reduce the heat to low. Simmer for about 40 minutes, or until the lentils are softened and the liquid is mostly absorbed.
3. Add the remaining coconut milk and continue to **cook** over low heat for another 10 minutes.
4. While the lentils are cooking, **mix** the almond butter and tomato paste in a small bowl with the remaining ½ cup [125ml] of the stock until smooth. Stir into the pot of lentils. Season with additional salt and pepper if needed.
5. In a blender or food processor, **puree** 1 to 2 cups [250 to 500ml] of the cooked lentils with some of the liquid and return to the pot. Remove from the heat, stir in hot sauce to taste, and serve.

SERVES 4 TO 6

Orzo with fresh tomatoes and mozzarella

This is one of those special dishes that are simple yet bursting with flavor. It's best made during the summer months when tomatoes are at their peak and a light dish is welcome. Fresh tomato sauce here means no cooking is involved. That's why it is critical to make the effort to find the freshest, ripest tomatoes as well as fresh mozzarella. And, of course, use your best olive oil. **IMPORTANT . . .** prepare all your ingredients before you cook the pasta.

1 pound orzo [500g]

1½ to 2 pounds ripe, seasonal tomatoes, cut into ½-inch [1-cm] dice [750g to 1kg]

3 garlic cloves, minced

½ to ¾ pound fresh mozzarella cheese, finely diced [250 to 375g]

Salt and freshly ground pepper

¼ cup extra virgin olive oil [60ml]

½ cup shelled raw pistachios [55g]

¾ cup shredded basil leaves [200ml]

1. Bring at least 4 quarts [4L] salted water to a vigorous boil. **Add** the orzo and stir immediately and often until the water returns to a boil. Cook until the pasta is al dente (slightly resistant to the bite), then drain quickly into a colander. Shake out the water completely.
2. Put the hot, drained pasta into a large bowl. Add the tomatoes, garlic, and mozzarella; **toss** to mix well. Season generously with salt and pepper. Add the olive oil and pistachios and mix. Toss in the basil and mix once again. Serve at once.

SERVES 4 TO 6

Rosemary mushroom white bean pasta

The combination of beans and pasta is a **classic** Italian favorite. It's homey, comforting, and very easy to prepare. **NOTE:** This is a thick, chunky sauce. If you want more liquid in your pasta sauce, add a ½ cup [125 ml] or so pasta cooking water, vegetable stock, or white wine when you add the beans.

½ pound penne [250g]

1½ tablespoons olive oil

1 small onion, chopped

1 pound cremini mushrooms, sliced [500g]

1 tablespoon fresh rosemary, minced

2 garlic cloves, minced

1 teaspoon crushed hot red pepper

Salt and freshly ground black pepper

1 can (15 ounces) organic white beans,
liquid reserved [300g (drained)]

1 tablespoon tomato paste

1 tablespoon red wine vinegar

2 tablespoons coarsely chopped fresh
parsley

1. Bring at least 4 quarts [4L] salted water to a vigorous boil. **Add** the pasta and stir immediately and often until the water returns to a boil. Cook until the pasta is al dente (slightly resistant to the bite), then drain quickly into a colander. Shake out the water completely.
2. While pasta is cooking, **heat** the olive oil in a large skillet over medium heat. Add the onion and cook until softened and slightly browned, about 5 minutes. Add the mushrooms, rosemary, garlic, and hot pepper. Season with salt and black pepper. Cook until the mushrooms are tender, about 5 minutes.
3. Add the beans with their reserved liquid and the tomato paste; stir well. Bring to a boil. Reduce the heat and simmer 2 to 3 minutes. **Season** again, if necessary, with salt and pepper. Remove from the heat and add the vinegar. Stir in the cooked pasta. Toss to coat evenly. Garnish with parsley and serve.

SERVES 2

Simple Béchamel Sauce

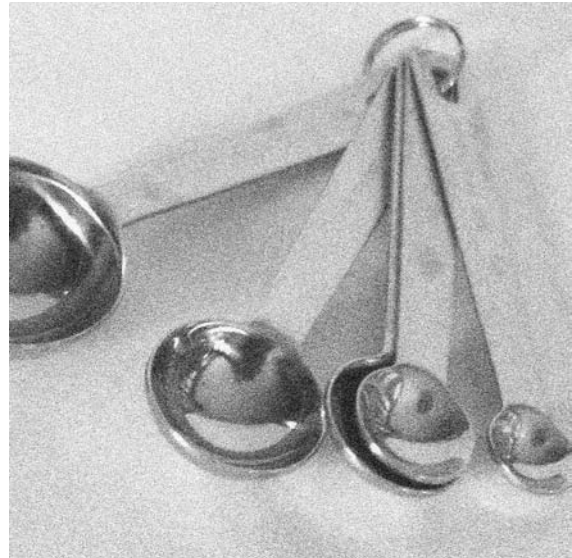
1½ cups whole milk, preferably organic
[375ml]

2½ tablespoons unbleached all-purpose flour

3 tablespoons butter, preferably organic

1. In a medium saucepan, **scald** the milk, but do not let it boil. Remove from the heat.
2. In another saucepan, **melt** the butter over medium-low heat. Add the flour and cook, stirring with wooden spoon, for 1 to 2 minutes, without allowing the mixture to color.
3. Remove the roux from the heat and slowly **whisk** in the milk, 2 to 3 tablespoons at a time, until about half has been added. Then slowly pour in the remaining milk and bring the sauce to a boil, whisking constantly, until it thickens. Reduce the heat to low and simmer for 5 minutes.

MAKES ABOUT 1 ½ CUPS [375ML]



Kale-garlic risotto with fresh mango

Many **risottos** contain cheese, though I made this one without any for my vegan friends across the aisle. Of course, if you are not vegan, you can always stir in some Parmesan cheese at the end.

1½ tablespoons olive oil or butter

1 small onion, finely chopped

2 cups packed dinosaur or other green kale, tough stems removed, leaves coarsely chopped [500ml]

3 garlic cloves, minced

1 cup arborio or other risotto rice [200g]

4 cups vegetable stock [1L], simmering

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1 large fresh mango, sliced

1. In a heavy-bottomed saucepan, heat the olive oil over medium-low heat. **Add** the onion and cook until softened and translucent, about 5 minutes. Add the kale and, stirring constantly, cook for about 1 minute, until it begins to soften and turns a brighter shade of green.
2. Add the garlic and stir for 30 seconds. Add the rice and cook, stirring constantly, for 1 to 1½ minutes. Raise the heat to medium-high and **ladle** in 1 cup [250ml] simmering stock. The liquid should quickly boil and continue to simmer.
3. Continue to **stir**, without stopping, reaching all sides and the bottom of the pan so the rice does not stick or burn. Keep stirring until the liquid is absorbed and evaporated. Ladle in ½ cup [125ml] more hot liquid and repeat the process until the pan is again void of much stock.
4. After 15 minutes or so, **season** with salt and pepper and get a quick taste. Is your rice too crunchy? It probably will be, but this is the time for you to make choices. Risotto should be tender but firm to the bite. You may add slightly less liquid now at each addition until you get your desired results in about 20 to 25 minutes.
5. When the risotto is done, remove it from the heat and season again generously with salt and pepper. **Garnish** with fresh mango. Serve immediately.

SERVES 2 TO 4

Basic polenta recipe

You will follow this basic recipe for all the polenta recipes in this chapter (and one in chapter 3). It's **straightforward** and easy to follow. For the very best results, use light-colored homemade or prepared vegetable stock. The only alterations to this recipe will be if you are doubling the amount or if you need a softer or firmer consistency. Techniques follow for those two variations.

5 cups light-colored vegetable stock, such as
Basic Vegetable Stock (page 45), or water
[1.25L]

1 cup polenta (coarse-ground cornmeal)
[130g]

Freshly ground pepper

1½ teaspoons salt

1. Bring the stock to a boil in a heavy medium pot. **Add** the salt and keep the water at a boil over medium-high heat.
2. Add the polenta in a very thin stream, either slowly from a measuring cup or letting a fistful of it run through nearly closed fingers, **stirring** all the while with a long-handled whisk to avoid lumps. Stirring constantly and keeping the water boiling, continue this procedure until all the cornmeal is added.
3. Reduce the heat to medium-low, enabling the cornmeal to simmer gently. You will realize the right temperature when the hot polenta no longer bubbles and pops back at you. (Remember, you want to enjoy the process of making polenta by not getting burned.) Continue stirring, switching to a long-handled wooden spoon. For an even, slow heat and to help avoid burning or sticking, use a flame-tamer or heat diffuser. **Stir** continuously and thoroughly, bringing the mixture up from the bottom and loosening it from the sides. Make sure to really scoop into the sides. Continue to stir for 15 to 25 minutes* or until the polenta is very creamy and pulls away from the sides of the pot. Season with additional salt and pepper to taste.

MAKES ABOUT 2 CUPS [500ML]

*For soft, loose polenta, cooking time is about 10 to 15 minutes. For firmer polenta, used for grilling or broiling, cook longer until it is thicker, about 20 to 25 minutes.

Creamy tomato sauce

Frying sauce after it is prepared is a Mexican-inspired technique, which adds an extra mellowness and depth of flavor. This easy preparation is perfect over grilled polenta with a stuffed pepper. It is a simple, lively sauce. Alternatively, if you like a smoother sauce, press the mixture through a fine-mesh strainer before adding the crème fraîche.

2 pounds ripe tomatoes, cored and halved lengthwise [1kg]

1 medium onion, chopped

2 tablespoons olive oil

3 garlic cloves, minced

1½ teaspoons salt

1 cup vegetable stock [250ml]

¼ cup crème fraîche or heavy cream [60ml]

Salt

1. Preheat the broiler with the rack set 5 to 6 inches [13 to 15cm] from the heat. Place the tomatoes, cut side down, on a baking sheet. **Broil** until the tomatoes are lightly charred and the skins are wrinkled and peeling, 5 to 7 minutes.
2. Let the tomatoes cool, then **peel** and coarsely chop them, saving their juices. Place in a blender or food processor.
3. In a medium frying pan or cast-iron skillet, **cook** the onion in 1 tablespoon of the olive oil over medium-low heat until very soft and lightly browned, about 7 to 9 minutes. Add the garlic and cook for another minute.
4. Add the onion-garlic mixture to the tomatoes. **Season** with the salt and puree until smooth.
5. In the same pan, **heat** the remaining oil over high heat. Add the puree to the pan (it should sizzle and bubble), reduce the heat to medium-high, and cook for about 5 minutes, stirring constantly. *Warning:* The puree may splatter.
6. **Stir** in the vegetable stock and return to a boil, then reduce the heat to low and simmer uncovered for about 15 minutes, or until the sauce begins to thicken. Remove from the heat and stir in the crème fraîche. Season with additional salt to taste.

MAKES ABOUT 3 CUPS [750ML]

Burgundy garlic sauce

A simple, classically inspired sauce restructured slightly by adding soy sauce and miso for a deeper flavor.

1 bottle burgundy or other red wine [750ml]	2 tablespoons butter or olive oil [30g]
2 teaspoons soy sauce	1 tablespoon unrefined cane sugar
6 garlic cloves, crushed through a press	½ teaspoon red miso
2 cups vegetable stock [500ml]	½ teaspoon salt
2 tablespoons whole wheat flour	

1. In a large nonreactive saucepan, **combine** the wine, soy sauce, and garlic. Bring to a boil over medium-high heat. Cook until the wine is reduced by half. Add the stock and return to a boil. Again cook until the liquid is again reduced by about half. Set aside.
2. In a large dry skillet, **toast** the flour over medium-low heat, shaking the pan constantly, until the flour is fragrant and beige, 1 to 2 minutes. Watch carefully, because flour can burn quickly.
3. Immediately add the butter and **whisk** until melted and smooth. Gradually whisk in the wine reduction. Bring to a boil, whisking, until the sauce is smooth and thickened. Reduce the heat to low and continue to whisk for 30 to 60 seconds longer.
4. Stir in the sugar, miso, and salt. **Simmer** for 1 to 2 minutes longer.

MAKES ABOUT 2 CUPS [500 ML]

Savory seitan strips with sweet and sour sauce

This makes great use of the Dark Meat Seitan Braising Liquid. After cooking the seitan, the leftover marinade is reduced to concentrate the flavors. The sweet and sour sauce is added for an **unusual** combination. Almost by accident, I found that when the two liquids are combined, a very enjoyable taste develops that unites yet continues to highlight each flavor in just the right blend. Serve hot over rice or noodles.

TIP: You will need to make the Sweet and Sour Sauce first, I suggest doing this while the Dark Meat Seitan is cooking.

1 recipe Dark Meat Seitan (page 234)

1 medium onion, chopped

2 tablespoons olive oil

½ pound cremini mushrooms, thinly sliced
[250g]

½ teaspoon salt

⅛ teaspoon freshly ground pepper

1¼ cups Sweet and Sour Sauce (page 243)
[325ml]

1 tablespoon arrowroot

1. Remove the cooked seitan from its braising liquid and cut it into sticks measuring about 2 inches by ½ inch [5 by 1cm]. **Strain** the braising liquid into a measuring cup, pouring enough to equal 1½ cups [375ml]. Reserve separately.
2. In a large skillet, **sauté** the onion in the olive oil over medium-high heat oil until slightly browned, 3 to 5 minutes. Add the mushrooms and cook for another 5 minutes, or until they have softened. Season with the salt and pepper. Add the reserved liquid, reduce the heat to medium-low, and simmer for 10 minutes, stirring occasionally. Add the Sweet and Sour Sauce and simmer 10 minutes longer.
3. Stir the arrowroot into the remaining ½ cup [125ml] liquid and mix until smooth. **Stir** into the mushroom sauce in the pan and bring to a boil, stirring for another minute or so, until thickened and smooth.

SERVES 4

Crispy sweet and hot orange seitan

A crispy beef recipe I used to eat a lifetime ago in a Chinese restaurant far, far away **inspired** this dish. I use my sweet and sour sauce recipe with two slight changes: orange juice for the mango and a bit more sugar. For this recipe, you'll need both a large cast-iron skillet and a wok. Serve with rice and a salad.

Sweet and Sour Sauce (recipe follows)

2 tablespoons peanut or safflower oil

10 dried Thai or other hot red chiles
(1 to 3 broken open)

3 garlic cloves, minced

½ recipe Dark Meat Seitan (page 234), cut
into thin strips

2 carrots, cut into thin strips

3 stalks celery, cut into thin strips

1. Make the Sweet and Sour Sauce and set aside.
2. Preheat the oven to 375°F [190°C]. **Heat** 1 tablespoon of the peanut oil in a cast-iron skillet over medium-high heat. Add the chiles and garlic and cook for 30 seconds, stirring often. Add the seitan strips and stir a few times. Add the sweet and sour sauce and bring to a simmer. Cook, stirring constantly, for 10 minutes, or until most of the sauce has been absorbed by the seitan and the rest coats the strips.
3. Transfer the seitan in the skillet to the oven and **bake** for about 20 minutes, stirring once or twice. Remove and let cool; the seitan will become crisp.
4. In a wok or a large skillet, **heat** the remaining 1 tablespoon oil over high heat. Add the carrots and celery and cook, stirring often, until barely softened, about 1 minute. Add the seitan and continue to cook, stirring, until heated through, about 1 minute.

SERVES 2

Sweet and sour sauce

½ cup finely chopped onion [70g]

1 tablespoon peanut or safflower oil

1 cup frozen or fresh pitted cherries,
coarsely chopped [150g]

1¼ cups orange juice [325ml]

⅔ cup sherry vinegar or red wine vinegar
[150ml]

⅓ cup unrefined cane sugar [70g]

1½ teaspoons tamarind paste

1. In a nonreactive medium saucepan with a heavy bottom, **cook** the onion in the peanut oil over medium-low heat until very soft but not brown, 5 to 7 minutes.
2. **Add** the cherries, orange juice, vinegar, and sugar. Bring to a boil, cover, and reduce the heat to a bare simmer. Cook for 10 minutes. Uncover and cook 10 minutes longer, stirring occasionally so the sauce does not stick to the bottom or sides of the pan.
3. Pass the sauce through a food mill or fine mesh strainer and **press** through until the solids are practically dry. Return the sauce to the pan, stir in the tamarind paste, and simmer uncovered for 5 minutes, or until the sauce is reduced enough to coat a spoon heavily.

MAKES ABOUT 1 ½ CUPS [375G]

Garlic Baby Spinach

I like the soft mellowneSS of baby spinach combined with the sharpness of the garlic. Cooked for just a minute or two, the spinach is done when it turns bright green. If cooked longer, the leaves will throw off too much liquid and shrivel up. For additional color and flavor, sauté finely diced red bell peppers with the spinach. Serve with Shiitake-Apple Risotto (page 210) and Blackened Fruit Jerk Tempeh (page 150).

½ cup finely chopped onion [50g]

1 tablespoon olive oil

4 garlic cloves, minced

½ teaspoon crushed hot red pepper

12 ounces baby spinach leaves [375g]

¼ cup vegetable stock or water [60 ml]

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1. In a large skillet, **cook** the onion in the olive oil over medium heat until very soft and lightly browned, about 5 minutes. Add the garlic and hot pepper and continue to cook for 1 minute longer.
2. Raise the heat to medium-high and add the spinach and vegetable stock. **Season** with salt and pepper. Use tongs or 2 wooden spoons to mix and turn the leaves several times. The spinach will wilt and turn a vivid green quickly. Remove with a slotted spoon and serve.

SERVES 2

Moroccan carrots with cumin and lemon

Tangy, **tasty**, and pretty to look at, this dish can be served warm, cold, or at room temperature. Baby carrots—the real ones with their green tops still intact, not bagged—prepared the same way as the whole ones called for here also make an outstanding presentation.

8 medium carrots, roughly the same length,
peeled, ends trimmed, left whole

3 tablespoons fresh lemon juice

2 teaspoons olive oil

1 garlic clove, crushed through a press

½ teaspoon ground cumin

½ teaspoon sweet paprika

½ teaspoon unrefined cane sugar

¼ teaspoon salt

2 tablespoons coarsely chopped parsley

1. **Steam** the carrots until tender, 7 to 10 minutes.
2. While the carrots are steaming, **mix** together the lemon juice, olive oil, garlic, cumin, paprika, sugar, and salt in a small bowl to make a dressing.
3. When the carrots are done, transfer them to a shallow serving dish. **Drizzle** the dressing over the carrots and roll them with your fingers to make sure they are well coated. Garnish with the parsley.

SERVES 4

Glazed carrots with fresh nutmeg

The history of nutmeg goes back many centuries. As with many herbs and spices, long before nutmeg was used in the kitchen, it was valued for other perceived valuable properties. It was used medicinally, as an aphrodisiac, and as a fumigant. Culinarily speaking, **freshly grated** is the ideal way to use this spice. Ground nutmeg loses its flavor very quickly. If you don't have a nutmeg grater, I recommend this inexpensive purchase; you will really appreciate the results.

5 medium carrots, peeled and cut into diagonal slices about ¼ inch [.5 cm] thick

1½ tablespoons butter [25g] or olive oil

1½ tablespoons unrefined cane sugar

¼ teaspoon freshly grated nutmeg

Salt

1. **Steam** the carrot slices until just barely tender, 5 to 7 minutes.
2. In a large cast-iron skillet or sauté pan, **melt** the butter or heat the olive oil over medium-high heat.
3. Add the carrots and **sauté** until lightly browned on both sides, tossing and stirring frequently, 2 to 3 minutes.
4. Add the sugar to the skillet and toss until it melts and the carrots are glazed, about 1 minute. Remove from the heat, **dust** with the nutmeg, and season with salt to taste.

SERVES 4

Roasted root vegetables

Roasting **caramelizes** the sugar in vegetables, highlighting their natural sweetness and enhancing their flavor. If they are organic, simply scrub and cut as directed. Done correctly, roasted vegetables are really beautiful—simple but delicious. I recommend topping the vegetables with Cranberry Balsamic Vinaigrette (page 282) and serving Almond Coconut Dal (page 177) on the side.

3 or 4 Jerusalem artichokes, scrubbed and sliced

½ celery root, peeled and sliced

2 large carrots, scrubbed and sliced

1 head of garlic, cloves separated, peeled, and left whole

3 shallots, thinly sliced

3 cipolini or 1 medium onion, sliced

2 parsnips, peeled and sliced

1 medium sweet potato, scrubbed and sliced

1 medium baking potato, scrubbed and sliced

1½ tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

Salt and freshly ground pepper

Splash of cider vinegar or balsamic vinegar

1. **Preheat** the oven to 375°F [190°C]. Place all the cut vegetables in a large bowl. Add the olive oil and toss to coat.
2. Spread out the vegetables on a large baking sheet or shallow baking dish. **Season** with salt and pepper to taste.
3. Roast for 45 minutes to 1 hour, turning with a wide spatula several times, until lightly browned and soft. You want a slightly crisp, brown outside while maintaining a soft center. **Transfer** to a serving bowl and toss with a splash of vinegar.

SERVES 4

chef's tip

For a professional-looking presentation, stack roasted vegetables in an imaginative way, like kindling for a fire, making sure they are evenly distributed among servings.

Golden and red beets with toasted garlic

Beets are very **nutritious** and one of nature's best internal bodily cleansers and detoxifiers. Overlap the beets in a circle; toss the garlic on top or in the center. Alternately, if the beets are super-large, cut them in half before slicing.

1 large round red beet, peeled and sliced
into ¼-inch [.5-cm] rounds

1 head of garlic, cloves separated and
peeled, hard bits cut off, sliced in half

1 large round golden beet, peeled and sliced
into ¼-inch [.5-cm] rounds

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1 teaspoon red wine vinegar

2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

1. **Steam** the beets, either separately in 2 batches or in a double-decker steamer, until just tender, 7 to 10 minutes. Remove to separate plates and let cool.
2. In a large cast-iron or nonstick skillet, **heat** the olive oil over medium heat. Add the garlic and cook, stirring often, until lightly browned, about 2 minutes. With a slotted spoon, remove the garlic to a small bowl.
3. Add the beets to the garlic oil left in the pan. **Cook** over medium heat until heated through and well coated with the oil, about 2 minutes. Toss in the garlic for one last twirl around the pan. Season with salt and pepper and a spritz of vinegar.

SERVES 4

Cauliflower millet puree

Millet, which in North America is grown primarily for birdseed, has been around since ancient times. It was a mainstay of the Chinese diet even before rice. It is a nutritious grain, with a profusion of minerals and vitamins. Its somewhat bland flavor makes it appealing as a base on which to build other flavors.

This is a very **comforting** side dish, much like mashed potatoes but with a slightly nutty flavor. It also happens to be extremely nutritious. It makes an excellent accompaniment to three dishes: Roasted Vegetables (page 257), Crisp Tempeh with Honey-Mustard Sauce (page 152), and Citrus Tofu Cutlets (page 122).

1 pound cauliflower, cut into florets [500g]

½ cup millet [100g]

2 large shallots or 1 small onion, minced

1¼ cups vegetable stock or water [325ml]

3 garlic cloves, minced

¼ cup plain yogurt, preferably organic [60ml]

3 tablespoons olive oil

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1. Boil or steam the cauliflower florets until tender, about 10 minutes. **Drain** and run under cold water until cool. Set aside.
2. In a medium, heavy-bottomed saucepan, **cook** the shallots and garlic in 1 tablespoon of the oil over medium heat until softened but not browned, about 2 minutes.
3. Add the millet and toast for another minute, **stirring** frequently with a wooden spoon. Add the stock and bring to a boil. Reduce to a simmer and cook until tender. If the liquid evaporates before the millet is done, add a small amount of water and continue cooking until tender.
4. In a food processor, **puree** the cauliflower until smooth. With the machine on, add the remaining 2 tablespoons oil, the yogurt, and a generous amount of salt and pepper. Add the millet and blend again until well incorporated. If not serving right away, keep warm in the oven or on the stovetop over very low heat.

SERVES 4

Curried cauliflower, carrots, and potatoes

Packed with **lively** taste, this vegetable ragout can serve as a substantial side dish or as a satisfying entree, depending on the rest of the meal. The rich brown sauce tastes complex, but it's your secret that the ingredients are simple: curry, white wine, a little miso, tomato paste, and sugar. If serving as a main dish, add a cup of chickpeas or some cubes of tofu for additional protein.

2 carrots, cut into bite-size chunks

3 medium-size red potatoes, cut into $\frac{3}{4}$ -inch [2-cm] chunks

$\frac{1}{4}$ pound cauliflower, divided into florets [125g]

$\frac{1}{2}$ onion, minced

1 tablespoon olive oil

2 tablespoons curry powder

1 cup dry white wine [250ml]

1 tablespoon tomato paste

2 teaspoons unrefined cane sugar

1 $\frac{1}{2}$ teaspoons chickpea miso

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1 cup frozen peas

$\frac{1}{2}$ tart apple, coarsely chopped

1. **Steam** the carrots and potatoes until tender, about 10 minutes. Add the cauliflower and cook for an additional 2 minutes, or until tender but not mushy. Set aside.
2. In a large skillet, **cook** the onion in the olive oil over medium heat until lightly browned, about 5 minutes. Add the curry powder and cook, stirring, 30 to 60 seconds longer.
3. Increase the heat slightly and add $\frac{1}{2}$ cup [125ml] of the wine. Bring to a **boil** and stir in the tomato paste, sugar, and miso. Add the remaining wine. Cook, stirring, until a nice thick sauce forms. Season with salt and pepper to taste.
4. Add the steamed vegetables and **stir** to coat well with the curry sauce. Add the peas and apple, reduce the heat to low, and simmer for 2 minutes.

SERVES 4 TO 6

Twice-baked potatoes with roasted garlic and crispy shallots

This is so tasty and so easy, it's just plain **remarkable**. • Serve with a side of sautéed Sugar Snap Peas and Red Pepper (page 253) or a salad.

2 baking potatoes, 10 to 12 ounces
[300 to 350g] each

4 garlic cloves, roasted

2 tablespoons grated sharp Cheddar cheese

1 teaspoon fresh thyme, minced, or ½
teaspoon dried thyme

¼ cup plain soy milk [60ml]

Salt and freshly ground pepper

Extra virgin olive oil

⅓ cup canola or safflower oil [75ml]

4 medium shallots, thinly sliced

1. Preheat the oven to 375°F [190°C]. **Bake** the potatoes until soft, 45 minutes to 1 hour. Remove the potatoes, but leave the oven on.
2. **Roast** the garlic cloves in a dry cast-iron skillet over medium heat, turning often, until softened and browned in spots, 10 to 15 minutes. Peel and coarsely chop.
3. As soon as the potatoes are cool enough to handle, **slice** a piece off the top 3 to 4 inches long [8 to 10cm] and about ½ inch deep [1cm]. Gently scoop out the potatoes into a bowl, being careful not to tear the shell. Add the roasted garlic, cheese, and thyme and mash all together until the potato is smooth. Blend in the soy milk. Season with salt and pepper to taste. Scoop the mashed potato back into the shells.
4. Place the stuffed potatoes in a small baking dish. **Drizzle** the olive oil over the tops and return to the oven. Bake for 10 to 15 minutes, until lightly browned on top.
5. While the potatoes are baking the second time, **heat** the canola oil in a small saucepan over medium-high heat. Fry the shallots in small batches until golden brown, 2 to 3 minutes per batch. With a slotted spoon, scoop out the shallots and drain on paper towels. Sprinkle with salt. Cascade the crispy shallots over the top of the twice-baked potatoes and onto the plate.

SERVES 2

Roasted potatoes with arugula and aged vinegar

Roasted potatoes, much like roasted vegetables, are a quintessentially elegant food. They are uncomplicated but exceedingly rich in flavor. They even taste good cold. To complement their smoky taste, use your best aged vinegar. I recommend serving this dish with Light Meat Seitan (page 232) and a salad.

1 pound red potatoes, cut into quarters or eighths, depending on size [500g]

2 tablespoons olive oil

Salt

½ red onion, thinly sliced

1 small bunch of arugula, tough stems removed

1 tablespoon aged sherry vinegar or balsamic vinegar

1. Preheat the oven to 375°F [190°C]. **Toss** the potatoes with 1 tablespoon of the olive oil to coat. Season liberally with salt. Spread out on a baking sheet and roast, turning with a spatula once or twice, for 40 to 50 minutes, or until browned and crispy on the outside and tender inside. Set aside in a medium bowl.
2. In a medium-size cast-iron or other heavy skillet, **heat** the remaining tablespoon oil over medium-high heat. Add the red onion and sauté until lightly browned, about 5 minutes. Add the arugula and toss for 15 to 30 seconds, until just wilted and still bright green.
3. Add the onions and arugula to the roasted potatoes and mix well. **Sprinkle** on the vinegar, toss, and serve warm.

SERVES 4

Roasted cauliflower and mushroom Bhutanese red rice

Cooked Bhutanese red rice has a beautiful red russet color. Its slightly nutty taste blends perfectly with browned butter and pine nuts, giving it a real **SASSY** flavor. Roasting cauliflower is an excellent technique, which enhances a vegetable that admittedly can be a tad on the boring side.

4 ounces cremini mushrooms, sliced [125g]

12 ounces cauliflower, trimmed and cut into slices ½-inch [1-cm] thick

1½ tablespoons olive oil

1½ teaspoon salt

1 cup Bhutanese red rice [200g]

2½ cups vegetable stock or water [625ml]

4 tablespoons unsalted butter, preferably organic

½ cup pine nuts [100g]

Chopped parsley, for garnish

1. Preheat the oven to 400°. On a large baking sheet, arrange the mushrooms and cauliflower separately. **Toss** both with the olive oil to coat lightly. Sprinkle with ⅛ teaspoon of the salt.
2. **Roast** for 15 to 20 minutes, until the mushrooms are soft and slightly shriveled. Remove the mushrooms to a plate and set aside. Turn over the cauliflower and continue to roast until it is tender and lightly browned around the edges, 5 to 10 minutes longer.
3. Meanwhile, **cook** the rice in the stock with the remaining 1 teaspoon salt, covered, until tender, about 15 minutes. Set aside in the covered pot.
4. In a small pan, **melt** the butter over medium-low heat. After the foam has settled, add the pine nuts. Continue to cook for another 1 to 2 minutes, stirring often, until the nuts begin to brown. Remove from the heat.
5. In a large bowl, toss the rice, cauliflower, and mushrooms. **Pour** the butter and pine nuts over the rice mixture. Garnish with parsley and serve.

SERVES 4 TO 6

Wild rice and barley with olives and almonds

What I find interesting about this **full-bodied** dish is that two disparate grains cook well together and at the same time. They hold their individual colors and complement each other: one with a slight crunch, the other with a familiar creaminess.

This dish is an exceptional “bring along” for a potluck. It matches beautifully alongside Frittata with Oven-Dried Tomatoes (page 76).

¾ cup wild rice [150g]

½ cup pearled barley [100g]

4 cups vegetable stock or water [950ml]

1½ teaspoons salt

¼ cup kalamata olives, pitted and sliced
[50g]

¼ cup toasted almonds, slivered [50g]

½ fresh tart apple, diced

½ small red onion, thinly sliced, rinsed
under cold water

2 tablespoons fresh lemon juice

3 scallions, thinly sliced

1. In a medium saucepan, **bring** the wild rice, barley, stock, and 1 teaspoon salt to a boil. Reduce the heat, cover, and simmer for 45 to 50 minutes, or until the rice and barley are tender. Remove from heat and set aside, covered to keep warm.
2. Meanwhile, in a large bowl, **toss** together the olives, almonds, apple, red onion, olive oil, and lemon juice. Add the wild rice and barley to the bowl and mix thoroughly. Serve warm or at room temperature.

SERVES 4 TO 6

Jasmine rice with toasted garlic

Because jasmine rice cooks so quickly, it's excellent for a fast side dish. Feel free to toast the garlic in advance so you don't have to rush and risk burning it while you're busy making the rest of the meal.

2 tablespoons olive oil

6 garlic cloves, thinly sliced

Salt

1 cup jasmine rice [200g]

2½ cups vegetable stock or water [625ml]

1. In a small saucepan, **heat** the olive oil over low heat. Add the garlic and cook very slowly, stirring frequently, until lightly browned and toasted, 3 to 5 minutes. The key is to cook at a snail's pace so the garlic doesn't burn and turn bitter. Immediately scoop out the garlic with a slotted spoon and set aside on a small plate. Season lightly with salt.
2. Raise the heat to medium-high, **add** the rice, and stir for about 1 minute, until most of the grains turn from opaque white to translucent. Add in the stock and 1 teaspoon salt and bring to a boil. Cover and reduce to a simmer; cook until tender, about 15 minutes.
3. Keeping the pan covered, remove from the heat and let stand for 5 minutes before serving. **Top** each serving with some of the toasted garlic slices.

SERVES 4

chef's note

Rice is often the perfect accompaniment for so many dishes. Some are surprisingly simple, and that's just the way you want them. Others are complex, both in flavor and preparation—and that's okay, too, for the right occasion. But no matter how easy or hard, rice can be a tricky proposition. Prepare it the exact same way on different days, and it comes out differently each time. Maybe the lid wasn't tight enough or the heat was slightly higher or the rice was older or the saucepan was not heavy enough. I guess it's like cooking in general—influenced by a variety of nuances. So take your rice cooking with a grain of salt, so to speak, and just enjoy.

Roasted CORN and mushroom salad

Your options are endless as to what you might put in this salad. Some of the ingredients are cooked and some are raw to take advantage of a **variety** of flavors and textures.

4 ears of corn

½ onion, chopped

2 tablespoons plus 2 teaspoons extra virgin olive oil

2 garlic cloves, minced

10 fresh shiitake mushrooms, stemmed, caps sliced

2 teaspoons ground cumin

1 teaspoon chickpea miso or white miso

Salt and freshly ground pepper

Juice of 1 lime

½ red bell pepper, finely diced

½ cucumber, peeled, seeded, and finely diced

2 teaspoons apple cider vinegar

1 avocado, sliced

Chopped watercress or other greens, for serving

1. **Shuck** the corn and set the kernels aside. Scrape any excess milk from the cobs with the back of a knife and set it aside in a large bowl. In a very hot cast-iron skillet, roast the corn kernels until lightly browned, stirring often with a wooden spoon. If the corn sticks excessively, add a few drops of oil. Add the roasted corn to the bowl with the corn milk.
2. Cook the onion in the same skillet in 2 tablespoons of the olive oil over medium-high heat, until lightly browned, 3 to 5 minutes. **Add** the garlic and mushrooms. Cook until the mushrooms are soft, about 5 minutes. Stir in the cumin and miso. Season with salt and pepper to taste.
3. Add the contents of the pan to the corn and mix well. Let cool slightly. Add the lime juice, bell pepper, and cucumber. **Toss** with the vinegar and remaining oil and season again with salt and pepper. Top with the avocado slices. Serve on a bed of chopped watercress or other greens.

SERVES 4 TO 6

Marinated grilled portobello mushrooms

Grilled portobellos with a good marinade are like heaven. They have a smoky, succulent, meaty flavor and make an excellent sandwich with almost any savory spread. You can fry portobellos in a sauté pan, but don't expect the same results. The fire and smoke from the grill create a flavor and texture that the kitchen stove cannot replicate.

4 portobello mushrooms, 3 to 4 inches
[8 to 10cm] in diameter

¼ cup toasted sesame seed oil [60ml]

3 tablespoons dry red wine

1 tablespoon soy sauce

1 tablespoon balsamic or red wine vinegar

Juice of ½ lemon

2 garlic cloves, crushed through a press

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1. Remove the mushroom stems; save them for stock, if you like. Wipe the caps clean with damp paper towels. **Mix** all the remaining ingredients except the salt and pepper together in a small shallow bowl to make the marinade.
2. One at a time, **submerge** each mushroom in the marinade for just a few seconds. Lift out and twist gently to squeeze any excess liquid back into the bowl.
3. Light a medium-hot fire in a barbecue grill. Place the mushrooms gill side down on the oiled grill rack. **Cook** for 3 to 5 minutes, brushing the tops once with some of the marinade left in the bowl, until the bottoms have begun to soften but the mushrooms have not yet given up their juices. Turn over, brush again with marinade, and grill for another 4 to 6 minutes, until the mushroom caps are tender and lightly browned and the juices have welled up in the hollows.
4. **Transfer** the mushrooms to a cutting board, being careful not to spill the juices. Let them rest for a few minutes to allow the juices to penetrate. With a sharp knife, slice each cap into thin strips. Fan out the slices on a plate, splash with vinegar, and season lightly with salt and pepper.

SERVES 4

Caramelized pearl onions with toasted almonds

Looking for a fun holiday dish—maybe something a little different—guaranteed to solicit raves and cravings for more? Caramelized pearl onions are uncomplicated yet rather clever. This is a side dish with the sweet qualities of a dessert, not unlike other popular Thanksgiving standards, like candied sweet potatoes. Most of this recipe can be prepared ahead of time, making it **ideal** when you're asked to bring a side dish. The finishing touches can be done in just a few minutes.

½ cup slivered almonds [40g]

½ teaspoon salt

2 tablespoons canola or safflower oil

3 to 4 tablespoons maple syrup

24 to 35 small pearl or white onions, peeled

1. Preheat the oven to 325°F [160°C]. **Spread** out the almonds in a small baking dish and toast in the oven for 7 to 10 minutes, stirring several times, until lightly browned. Watch them carefully, as nuts can burn quickly and often unexpectedly.
2. Heat the canola oil in a large skillet over medium heat. **Add** the onions and salt and cook, rolling the onions about from time to time to prevent burning, for 20 to 25 minutes, or until they are golden to dark brown.
3. Reduce the heat to low. **Drizzle** the maple syrup over the onions. Cook, stirring, for 1 to 2 minutes, until the onions are glazed.
4. Remove from the heat. **Add** the toasted almonds and stir to mix.

SERVES 4 TO 6

note If not serving right away, prepare the onions through Step 2; cover and set aside at room temperature for up to 2 hours, or refrigerate. When ready, reheat the onions, then add the maple syrup and almonds.

Spicy mustard potato salad

I like two kinds of potato salad—traditional, with mayo and celery, and crazy, mixed-up, and **Wild**, as in this recipe. Okay, so it's not that wild. But I did add a few ingredients not always found in potato salad, like caraway, jalapeño, lemon juice, and roasted red bell peppers. I'll leave it up to you whether to keep it vegan or not by choosing mayonnaise or my tofu-based sour "cream."

1 pound medium red potatoes, scrubbed, cut into quarters or eighths, depending on size

1 small fresh jalapeño pepper, seeds and ribs removed, minced

1 tablespoon stone-ground or Dijon mustard

1 tablespoon caraway seeds

1 tablespoon finely diced roasted red bell pepper

1 tablespoon fresh lemon juice

1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil

½ cup frozen peas

1 teaspoon salt

¼ teaspoon freshly ground pepper

3 to 4 tablespoons Simple Sour Cream (page 48) or mayonnaise

2 scallions, thinly sliced on the diagonal

½ to 1 teaspoon paprika

1. **Steam** the potatoes just until tender. While they are cooking, put the jalapeño, mustard, caraway seeds, roasted peppers, lemon juice, and olive oil in a large bowl. Add the warm potatoes and mix very well.
2. Keep the water in the steamer boiling and add the peas. Steam until just tender, 3 to 5 minutes; drain. While the peas are cooking, season the salad with the salt and pepper. **Stir** in the Simple Sour Cream or mayonnaise and gently mix well. Add the peas, scallions, and paprika and mix again.

SERVES 4

Curried chickpeas

If you have fresh chickpeas, use them, of course, but if you're in the mood for curry in a **hurry**, toss in a couple of cans for a presto-chango deluxe side dish in minutes.

1 onion, chopped

2 tablespoons olive oil

4 cups cooked chickpeas

2 garlic cloves, minced

1½ tablespoons curry powder

⅔ cup vegetable stock or dry white wine

1 tablespoon tomato paste

2 teaspoons chickpea miso or white miso

Salt and freshly ground pepper

Fresh lemon juice

1. In a large skillet, **cook** the onion in the olive oil over medium heat until very soft and lightly browned, 7 to 9 minutes.
2. Add the chickpeas and garlic, then **stir** in the curry powder. Cook for about 1 minute, stirring often. Turn up the heat to medium-high and add the stock. Bring to a simmer.
3. Stir in the tomato paste and miso and season with salt and pepper. Cook, stirring, until the liquid has reduced and thickened, about 2 minutes. Remove from the heat and splash with lemon juice. **Season** again with salt and pepper to taste.

SERVES 4

Cranberry hazelnut relish

Highly refreshing, raw cranberries are a **great** palate pleaser, especially next to a spicy or savory dish. Try a spoonful in your mashed potatoes and then ask who's the bold vegetarian chef.

2 juicy tangerines

$\frac{1}{3}$ to $\frac{1}{2}$ cup maple syrup [75 to 125ml]

3 cups fresh cranberries [300g]

2 teaspoons grated fresh ginger

2 ripe Anjou pears, peeled, cored, and cut into chunks

2 tablespoons fresh lime juice

$\frac{1}{2}$ cup chopped toasted hazelnuts [45g]

Pinch of salt

1. **Peel** off the skin and as much of the white pith as possible from the tangerines. Peel the membrane from each segment and remove all seeds. Work over a bowl to catch as much of the juice as possible.
2. Place the tangerines and their juice, the cranberries, pears, hazelnuts, $\frac{1}{3}$ cup [75 ml] of the maple syrup, the ginger, lime juice, and salt into a food processor. **Pulse** a few times until chopped but still chunky. Taste and add the remaining maple syrup if you feel it's needed. Cover and refrigerate for at least 1 hour, or until serving time.

SERVES 6 TO 8

Crazy pecan cranberry sauce

During the holidays, I love tradition as much as the next guy, but sometimes I just get bored with the same old thing. If Mexico had Thanksgiving, I think they might serve this spicy, **SASSY** cranberry dish and its knockout topping. I like to decorate the top of the sauce with tangerines angled around in a circle.

1½ pounds fresh cranberries [750g]

¼ cup unrefined cane sugar [50g]

½ to 1 fresh jalapeño pepper, minced

½ cup coarsely chopped cilantro [125ml]

½ cup coarsely chopped pecans [50g]

1 tablespoon minced fresh ginger

Peeled sections from 2 seeded tangerines or oranges, for garnish*

1. In a large nonreactive saucepan, **cook** the cranberries with the sugar over medium heat until the berries soften and begin to pop, about 5 minutes.
2. Transfer to a bowl and stir in all the remaining ingredients except the tangerines. **Mix** well. Cover and refrigerate until cool.
3. Before serving, **decorate** with the tangerine sections.

SERVES 6

*In a pinch, mandarin orange sections will do.

Bibb lettuce salad with tempeh croutons

This is a simple salad with **bold** taste. The buttery, smooth leaves are a perfect match with the crisp, savory tempeh croutons. Choose a dressing that features the sharpness of garlic or the tartness of cranberries; either will liven up the greens and cause guests to sit up and notice.

¼ cup canola or safflower oil [60ml]

8 ounces tempeh, cut in half [250g]

Salt

1 large head of Bibb* or butter lettuce, thoroughly washed and dried, torn into bite-size pieces

Freshly ground pepper

¼ cup [30g] fresh raspberries or ¼ cup [40g] dried cranberries (optional)

CHOOSE YOUR DRESSING

Raspberry Garlic Dressing (recipe follows)

Cranberry Balsamic Vinaigrette (recipe follows)

1. In a medium skillet, **heat** the oil over medium-high heat. When just shimmering, add the tempeh squares and fry on one side until nicely browned and crisp but not burned, 2 to 3 minutes. Turn the tempeh over and brown the other side. Drain on paper towels. Sprinkle with salt while still warm.
2. When cooled, **cut** the tempeh into small cubes. Use a very sharp regular knife or a serrated knife for best results.
3. **Toss** the lettuce with 2 to 3 tablespoons of the dressing. Add the tempeh croutons and toss lightly again. Divide among 4 salad plates or bowls. Add a generous grinding of pepper and serve. Pass the remaining dressing on the side. If using raspberry dressing, top with a few fresh raspberries; if using cranberry, garnish the salads with dried cranberries.

* Sometimes Bibb is available in small heads only, so buy 2 or 3 depending on how many servings you need.

SERVES 4

Raspberry garlic dressing

This is an outstanding summer taste sensation. Raspberries and fresh garlic make an excellent combination and a naturally thick and creamy dressing. Be sure to reserve additional berries to toss in your salad.

2 tablespoons fresh raspberries

1 tablespoon raspberry vinegar

2 garlic cloves, minced

2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

1 tablespoon unrefined cane sugar

½ teaspoon salt

Puree all the ingredients in a blender until very well mixed. If you are a perfectionist, strain to remove the raspberry seeds.

MAKES ABOUT ⅓ CUP [75ML]

Cranberry balsamic vinaigrette

This is a rich, distinctively flavored dressing, perfect for a Bibb lettuce salad, mesclun greens, a warm wilted greens salad, or over grilled fruit or vegetables. Some stores have dozens of bags of cranberries frozen from the fall holiday season. If you haven't saved any yourself and are making this out of season, see if you can find a store that carries them.

2 tablespoons fresh or frozen cranberries

2 to 3 tablespoons maple syrup

2 tablespoons your best balsamic vinegar

Salt and freshly ground pepper

2 tablespoons plus 1 teaspoon extra virgin olive oil

Combine the cranberries, vinegar, olive oil, and 2 tablespoons maple syrup in a blender or mini food processor. Puree until very smooth. Season with salt and pepper to taste. If too tart, add more maple syrup.

MAKES ABOUT ½ CUP [125ML]

Roasted radicchio with arugula, endive, and fresh mozzarella

If you have never cooked radicchio, you are in for a **visual** and taste sensation. Its slightly charred burgundy-red leaves and mellowed nutty flavor are a sophisticated change of pace. I think cooking improves the traditional bitter-tart salad (radicchio and endive) with a savory, sweetened edge.

Roasted Garlic Dressing goes very well with this salad. If you prefer something with a sweet tang, try the Chipotle-Date Dressing with Lime, which has a modest bite.

2 tablespoons olive oil

1 head of radicchio, sliced into quarters,
root ends removed

1 bunch of arugula, cleaned, tough stems
removed

1 head of Belgian endive, cored and cut
lengthwise into thin strips

6 ounces fresh mozzarella, diced [180g]

3 medium-size ripe tomatoes, seeded and
cut into chunks

Salt and freshly ground pepper

CHOOSE YOUR DRESSING

Creamy Roasted Garlic Dressing (recipe
follows)

Chipotle-Date Dressing with Lime (recipe
on page 285)

1. In a large cast-iron skillet, **heat** the olive oil over medium-high heat until very hot. Add the radicchio and grill, turning, until browned and lightly blackened on at least 2 or 3 sides. Use tongs to turn the radicchio about so all sides are exposed to the skillet. Remove and let cool.
2. In a large salad bowl, **toss** the grilled radicchio with the arugula. Add 2 to 3 tablespoons of the dressing and toss again. Gently fold in the endive. Top with the mozzarella and tomatoes. Season with salt and pepper to taste. Serve immediately. Pass the remaining dressing on the side.

SERVES 4 TO 6

Creamy toasted garlic dressing

This savory, slightly tangy dressing is creamy, with a beautiful pale yellow color.

6 garlic cloves, skins on

1 tablespoon lemon juice

1 teaspoon mellow white miso

1½ teaspoons honey

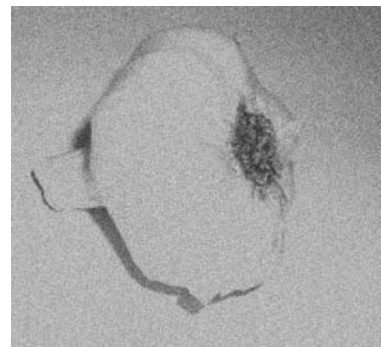
2½ tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

½ teaspoon salt

1 tablespoon apple cider vinegar

1. Heat a dry cast-iron skillet or heavy frying pan over medium heat. **Toast** the unpeeled garlic, turning over with tongs occasionally. Allow the garlic to brown in spots, about 15 minutes. Let cool, then peel and coarsely chop.
2. **Puree** the garlic along with the rest of the ingredients in a blender or mini food processor until smooth. Let the dressing stand for 1 hour before serving.

MAKES ABOUT ⅓ CUP [75ML]



Chipotle-date dressing with lime

The date in this recipe sweetens and thickens the dressing. It also dampens the heat of the chile while allowing the flavor and smokiness to shine through. As chiles vary widely in heat, start with half a chipotle. After blending, taste to see if the heat and flavor are where you want it. The key to this dressing is to achieve just a hint of heat and smoke.

I also like to use this dressing to top roasted veggies. With the addition of $\frac{3}{4}$ cup [200ml] apple juice or a combination of citrus juices, it makes a nice tofu marinade.

$\frac{1}{2}$ to 1 small chipotle chile, cracked open, stem and seeds removed

2 fresh dates, pits removed, quartered

3 tablespoons fresh lime juice

2 tablespoons juice from honey tangerine, tangelo, or other orange

3 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

1 tablespoon sherry vinegar or good-quality balsamic vinegar

1 teaspoon unrefined cane sugar

$\frac{1}{4}$ teaspoon salt

Freshly ground pepper

1. **Soak** the chipotle chile in 1 cup [250ml] hot water until soft, about 30 minutes. Remove from the water and coarsely chop.
2. In a blender or mini food processor, **combine** the chipotle with the dates, lime juice, citrus juice, olive oil, vinegar, sugar, salt, and a generous grinding of pepper. Puree until very smooth, scraping down the sides 2 or 3 times with a rubber spatula. For a smoother texture, press through a fine mesh strainer with a whisk.

MAKES ABOUT $\frac{1}{2}$ CUP [125 ML]

Chard, fresh fennel, and red onion salad with feta and mint

Modesty aside, this is an **outstanding** salad with all the characteristics of a classic. The Creamy Italian Dressing is a perfect accompaniment with its dried herb base. Roasted Tomato Vinaigrette goes beautifully, too, as a sweet-savory-tangy addition to the feta and herbs.

2 tablespoons olive oil

½ large red onion, very thinly sliced

1 fresh fennel bulb (about 6 ounces), stems removed, very thinly sliced, leaves reserved and coarsely chopped [180g]

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1 bunch of Swiss, red, or rainbow chard, tough stems removed, leaves thoroughly washed and dried, torn into bite-size pieces

4 sorrel leaves, shredded (optional)

6 mint leaves, shredded

4 ounces feta cheese, crumbled or cubed [125g]

CHOOSE YOUR DRESSING

Creamy Italian Dressing (recipe follows)

Roasted Tomato Vinaigrette (recipe on page 288)

1. In a large cast-iron skillet, **heat** the oil until very hot. Add the red onion to one side of the pan, the fennel to the other. Slowly cook over medium heat, turning and stirring with tongs, until soft and lightly browned. The onion and fennel may finish cooking at different times, so remove them as they are done. Season lightly with salt and pepper and set aside to cool while preparing your salad.
2. In a large bowl, **toss** the chard, sorrel, and mint. Toss again with 3 to 4 tablespoons of the dressing. Fold in the red onion and fennel. Top with the feta cheese.

SERVES 4

Creamy Italian dressing

This is somewhat like the Creamy Fresh Herb Dressing, but it has a distinctively Italian cast to it. So while it is also wide open to interpretation, given the blank slate of the tofu and herbs, it is geared to Mediterranean flavors.

¼ teaspoon dried thyme

¼ teaspoon dried basil

¼ teaspoon dried oregano

3 ounces silken tofu [90g]

1 teaspoon minced shallot

1 garlic clove, minced

1 tablespoon plus 1 teaspoon extra virgin olive oil

1 tablespoon red wine vinegar

1 teaspoon unrefined cane sugar

¼ teaspoon salt

1 tablespoon vegetable stock or water

1. **Combine** the thyme, basil, and oregano in a mortar and crush them with a pestle until well blended. If a mortar and pestle are not available, crumble the herbs between your fingers to release their flavors.
2. In a blender or food processor, **combine** the herbs with all the remaining ingredients and puree until very smooth and creamy. Add more liquid if you like a thinner dressing.

MAKES ABOUT ½ CUP [125ML]

Roasted tomato vinaigrette

A hint of cheese flavor comes in this bright and very savory dressing from the nutritional yeast. Besides being a bold vinaigrette for salads, this makes an excellent dip for fresh bread, in place of plain olive oil.

4 plum tomatoes, cored and halved lengthwise

1 tablespoon red wine vinegar

2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

1 teaspoon nutritional yeast

1 teaspoon unrefined cane sugar

1 garlic clove, minced

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1. **Preheat** the broiler with a rack set about 4 to 6 inches [10 to 15cm] from the heat.
2. Set out the tomatoes on a baking sheet, cut sides down. **Broil** until they are soft and the skins are cracked and lightly charred, 5 to 7 minutes. Let the tomatoes cool, then place them in a fine strainer set over a bowl.
3. With a whisk, **press** the tomato juice through the strainer. Continue to turn the sieve and whisk until all that is left is dry pulp. Discard the pulp or freeze it in your vegetable stock bag. Don't forget to scrape off the liquid that clings to the bottom of the strainer.
4. Whisk the vinegar, olive oil, nutritional yeast, sugar, and garlic into the roasted tomato juice. **Season** with salt and pepper to taste. If there is time, let the dressing stand for 1 hour at room temperature before serving, then mix well again.

MAKES ABOUT 1/4 CUP [60ML]

Russian dressing with sun-dried tomatoes

This popular bold dressing is especially thick. It works well with a hearty salad of greens and tomatoes or a spread for sandwiches. Add more tomato soaking liquid if you prefer a thinner dressing.

5 sun-dried tomatoes

1 small shallot, minced

4 ounces silken tofu [125g]

1 teaspoon vegetarian Worcestershire sauce

2 teaspoons bottled plain (not creamed)
red or white horseradish

1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil

½ teaspoon salt

1 tablespoon ketchup

Freshly ground pepper

1. **Soak** the tomatoes in 1 cup [250ml] hot water until soft, 15 to 20 minutes. Drain, reserving the soaking liquid. Coarsely chop the tomatoes.
2. Puree all the ingredients except the reserved soaking liquid in a blender or food processor, scraping down the sides 2 or 3 times until very smooth. With the machine on, **drizzle** in ⅓ to ½ cup [75 to 125ml] of the soaking liquid to achieve the desired consistency. Use more if necessary.

MAKES ABOUT 1 CUP [250ML]

Rainbow ribbon salad

Presentation is a very important part of this salad, so take your time and do it just right. The salad is **bright**, beautiful, and full of color. The shredded beet is essential to bringing it all together. Tofu adds a nice warm touch and a firm mouthfeel to accent the softer vegetables.

3 tablespoons vegetable oil

½ pound firm tofu, pressed of water, cut lengthwise in half [250g]

Salt

½ red bell pepper, cut into thin strips

½ yellow bell pepper, cut into thin strips

½ cucumber, seeded and cut into thin strips

1 medium carrot, peeled and cut into thin strips

½ green apple, cut into thin strips

½ cup shredded peeled fresh beet

CHOOSE YOUR DRESSING

Chipotle-Date Dressing with Lime (page 285)

Chinese Mustard Dressing (page 32)

1. In a cast-iron skillet, **heat** the vegetable oil over medium-high heat. Add the tofu cutlets and sauté until lightly browned and crispy on both sides, 2 to 3 minutes per side. Drain on paper towels. Sprinkle with salt while still warm. Cut into ½-inch [1-cm] cubes and set aside.
2. In a large bowl, **toss** the bell peppers, cucumber, carrot, and apple with 2 or 3 tablespoons of the dressing.
3. With tongs, portion out servings of the vegetable and apple mixture in the center of 4 salad plates, leaving the outer portion of the plate free for the tofu. **Top** each pile of rainbow salad with shredded beet. Place 4 or 5 tofu cubes around the outside of each plate. Serve immediately. Pass any remaining dressing on the side.

SERVES 4

Wilted greens with miso-tamarind sauce and caramelized pears

This is the kind of salad that often **surprises** people. It's unusual and interesting in flavor, and it looks beautiful in a large bowl or on individual plates. The browned pears are a special treat. This is a very nice salad for the fall season.

1 head of hearty leafy greens (for example: mustard, romaine, radicchio, endive, oak leaf, chard), cleaned and very coarsely chopped

1 firm but not hard Bosc pear

2 tablespoons vegetable oil

2 teaspoons maple syrup

1 teaspoon red miso or barley miso

1 teaspoon tamarind paste

1 teaspoon tomato paste

1 garlic clove, crushed through a press

1 tablespoon minced fresh ginger

½ cup vegetable stock or water [125ml]

1. **Prepare** the greens and set aside in a large bowl.
2. Quarter the pear and cut out the stem and core. **Cut** each quarter into 2 or 3 thin slices.
3. In a large skillet, **heat** the oil over medium-high heat. Add the pear slices and sauté until browned on both sides, 7 to 9 minutes. Drain on paper towels and set aside. Pour off any oil or juices in the skillet.
4. In a medium bowl, combine the maple syrup, miso, tamarind, tomato paste, garlic, ginger, and vegetable stock. **Whisk** until smooth. Pour into the pan and bring to a boil over medium-low heat. Cook, stirring, until the dressing begins to thicken, 1 to 2 minutes.
5. Immediately **pour** the hot dressing over the greens and toss until they are well coated and wilt slightly. Divide among salad plates (tongs work well) and top with pear slices. Serve immediately.

SERVES 2 TO 4

Herbed feta cheese with tomatoes and cucumbers

Man . . . if you'll pardon the expression—this is good stuff. Very simple to make and a wonderful presentation. This salad is especially suited to a summer meal or party. Serve the marinated cheese over tomatoes and cucumbers, as suggested here, or over your favorite mix of greens. Add a splash with balsamic or red wine vinegar if you prefer a bit of acid.

10 ounces feta cheese, cut into bite-size cubes [300g]

¼ cup extra virgin olive oil [60ml]

2 tablespoons fresh rosemary, coarsely chopped

2 tablespoons fresh oregano, coarsely chopped

Freshly ground pepper

3 large tomatoes, preferably beefsteaks or heirlooms, seeded and cut into bite-size cubes

1 large cucumber, sliced

1. Place the feta cheese, olive oil, rosemary, oregano, and a generous grinding of pepper in a heavy-duty sealable plastic bag. **Refrigerate** overnight, turning the bag 2 or 3 times.
2. **Serve** the cheese with its marinade over the tomatoes and cucumbers.

SERVES 6

Vegan Caesar salad

Here is a classic that has a bold, **zesty** flavor yet a fraction of the fat and calories of the original. No anchovies, no eggs, and no cheese, but all the bright taste.

1 large head of romaine lettuce

1 garlic clove, cut in half

1 cup bread or tempeh croutons [250ml]

½ recipe Hail Caesar Dressing (recipe follows)

Freshly ground pepper

1. **Separate** the lettuce leaves and tear them into large bite-size pieces. Rinse well and whirl dry in a salad spinner.
2. Rub a large salad bowl with the cut sides of the garlic. **Add** the lettuce, three-quarters of the croutons, ¼ cup [60ml] of the dressing, and a generous grinding of black pepper. Toss to mix well.
3. **Garnish** the salad with the remaining croutons and serve at once. Pass the remaining dressing on the side.

SERVES 4 TO 6

Hail Caesar Dressing

2 tablespoons slivered blanched almonds

2 garlic cloves, chopped

3 tablespoons Dijon mustard

3 tablespoons nutritional yeast

½ sheet toasted nori, crumbled

½ teaspoon salt

⅛ teaspoon freshly ground pepper

3 tablespoons fresh lemon juice

2 tablespoons soy sauce

1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil

About ¼ cup water [60ml]

Mix all the ingredients in blender, adding the water in increments until you achieve the thickness you desire. Scrape down the sides 2 or 3 times until very well mixed. Let the dressing rest for 1 hour before serving. Store any extra in a covered jar in the refrigerator for up to 3 days.

MAKES ABOUT 1 CUP [250ML]

No-bake chocolate cashew cake

Who would have thought of couscous for dessert? The bland grain presents an interesting **texture** and a perfect vehicle for picking up flavorings. The cake itself is composed of two rich layers in which all my favorite dessert flavors—at least the flavors I like: chocolate, vanilla, and coconut—are merged.

¼ cup shredded unsweetened coconut [15g]

1 cup raw, unsalted cashews [120g]

1½ cups coconut-pineapple juice* [375ml]

1¼ cup unrefined cane sugar [225g]

1 cup couscous [150g]

1½ tablespoons vanilla extract

10 ounces vegan or regular semisweet chocolate chips [300g]

2 packages (12.3 ounces each) firm or extra-firm silken tofu [700g total]

¼ cup maple syrup [60ml]

Pinch of salt

1. **Preheat** the oven to 350°F [175°C]. Place the coconut on a baking sheet and toast it in the oven until golden, about 5 minutes. Watch carefully, as it will burn quickly. Transfer to a plate and let cool.
2. In a blender, **puree** the cashews with 1 cup water [250 ml] until very smooth. In a medium saucepan, **combine** this cashew milk, the coconut-pineapple juice, sugar, and couscous. Mix well. Bring to a simmer and cook, stirring often, until thickened, 5 to 10 minutes. Remove from the heat and stir in the vanilla. Spread into an ungreased 9-inch [23-cm] springform pan. Let cool.
3. In a double boiler, **melt** the chocolate chips over low heat, stirring until smooth. Scrape into a food processor. Add the tofu, maple syrup, and salt. Process until very smooth.
4. Pour the chocolate tofu over the couscous layer. **Sprinkle** the toasted coconut evenly over the top. Refrigerate until the cake is set, at least 2 hours or, ideally, overnight.

SERVES 10 TO 12

*Knudsen brand makes a coconut-pineapple juice. It blends and unifies beautifully with the other flavors. If you cannot find it, substitute apple juice.

Vanilla maple pudding

This pudding goes beyond just mixing tofu with a particular flavoring. I felt compelled to challenge the status quo with a dairy-free pudding that had a proper mouthfeel and a **taste** you might expect from a more traditional pudding. The key seems to be the oil (don't substitute or leave out!) and the combination of a thickener, like arrowroot, and the vegetarian gelatin, agar.

1 package (12.3 ounces) firm or extra-firm silken tofu [350g]

¼ cup flavorless vegetable oil [60ml]

½ cup maple syrup [125ml]

1 tablespoon fresh lemon juice

Pinch of salt

2 tablespoons arrowroot

1 cup vanilla rice milk or soy milk [250ml]

1 cup apple, peach, or pear juice [250ml]

1 tablespoon agar flakes

2 tablespoons vanilla extract

Fresh strawberries or blueberries, for garnish

1. In a food processor, **combine** the tofu, oil, maple syrup, lemon juice, and salt. Blend until very smooth, at least 1 minute, scraping down the sides once or twice. Set aside.
2. In a measuring cup, **whisk** the arrowroot into the milk until blended.
3. In a medium saucepan, **heat** the apple juice over low heat. Add the agar and bring to a bare simmer, whisking constantly, until the flakes are completely dissolved. This may take several minutes, so be patient.
4. Reduce the heat to low. **Whisk** the milk-arrowroot mixture into the juice and continue to cook, stirring, until the mixture thickens, 1 to 2 minutes.
5. **Pour** the juice mixture into the tofu in the food processor. Add the vanilla and pulse just enough to blend. Do not overmix here, or the arrowroot may break down. Pour the mixture into individual dessert dishes or a single bowl. Decorate with berries while still warm. Cover and refrigerate until firmly set, about 2 hours.

SERVES 4

Sweet yogurt with raspberries

If you've never made yogurt cheese, you must try it. It's a very simple technique that does two things: It removes excess water from the yogurt, making it thicker and creamier, and it yields a sharper, **tangier** flavor. This particular combination makes an outstanding summer dessert when raspberries are at their plump finest.

32 ounces (2 quarts) plain yogurt, preferably organic [2L]

8 ounces crème fraîche [250ml]

1 teaspoon vanilla extract

9 tablespoons unrefined cane sugar [115g]

1½ pints fresh raspberries [375g]

Fresh mint leaves, for garnish

1. **Line** a fine mesh strainer with 2 layers of cheesecloth. Use enough cloth so that it hangs over the sides. Set the strainer over a bowl so there is 1 to 2 inches [2.5 to 5cm] of space between the bottom of the strainer and the bottom of the bowl. Pour the yogurt into the strainer and cover with plastic wrap or a plate. Refrigerate overnight.
2. Pour the crème fraîche into a medium bowl and stir until softened. Add the vanilla and 3 tablespoons of the sugar. **Stir** until the sugar dissolves.
3. Fold in the yogurt cheese and mix well. **Distribute** evenly among six 8-ounce [240g] custard cups or ramekins. Ideally, you'll want to leave ½ inch [1cm] or so of room for your topping. Refrigerate for at least 15 to 30 minutes.
4. In the meantime, place the raspberries into a bowl and set aside. **Add** the remaining sugar and ¼ cup [60ml] water to a saucepan over medium heat and bring to a light boil. Cook for 2 to 3 minutes, stirring frequently, until the sugar thickens slightly and turns golden.
5. Immediately **pour** the syrup over the raspberries and mix gently so they are well coated. Let cool for a few minutes. Spoon the raspberries and syrup over the yogurt cups and return to the refrigerator. Chill for 1 hour. Garnish with mint before serving.

SERVES 6

Orange and dried cherry salad

A mix of fresh and dried fruit makes for a perfectly **light**, slightly sweet, and fragrant dessert. Orange blossom water is available in Middle Eastern and Indian specialty shops.

5 large navel oranges

2 ounces dried tart cherries [60g]

2 teaspoons orange blossom water

2 teaspoons unrefined cane sugar

½ teaspoon ground cinnamon

¼ cup toasted, coarsely chopped almonds
[25g]

Fresh mint leaves, for garnish

1. Using a sharp knife, **cut** off the entire skin and white pith from the oranges. Place a strainer over a bowl to catch the juices and section the oranges between the white membranes so that you are left with nothing but orange—no skin or seeds.
2. Place the orange sections and dried cherries in a clean bowl. Add the orange blossom water, sugar, cinnamon, and almonds. **Toss** lightly to mix. Serve chilled, garnished with mint.

SERVES 4

Rum rice pudding

I've liked rice pudding since I was a kid. I like it mostly traditional, with white rice, milk, and sugar. Rum adds a **respectful** touch.

Vegetable cooking spray

½ cup raw long-grain white rice [100g]

2¼ cups whole milk [550ml]

½ cup light-colored unrefined cane sugar
[100g]

¼ teaspoon salt

3 tablespoons dark rum

½ teaspoon vanilla extract

⅓ cup toasted slivered almonds [30g]

Freshly grated nutmeg

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F [175°C]. **Coat** a covered baking dish with vegetable oil spray. In a medium bowl, mix together the rice, 2 cups [500ml] of the milk, the sugar, and the salt. Scrape into the baking dish. Cover with foil.
2. **Bake** for 45 minutes. Remove from the oven and give the pudding a good stir. It will still be quite loose. Don't worry; it is still in its infancy at this point.
3. Reduce the oven temperature to 325°F [160°C]. **Return** the dish to the oven and bake, covered, for another 20 to 30 minutes, or until most of the milk is absorbed.
4. Remove from the oven and, while still hot, stir in the rum, vanilla, and almonds. Stir in the remaining ¼ cup [60ml] milk. **Dust** with nutmeg. Serve warm.

SERVES 4

Berry-ginger merlot sauce over ice cream

This recipe is **perfect** for cranberries you froze in the fall. Or use your favorite seasonal berries. Blueberry, strawberry, blackberry—the combination is your choice.

1 cup berries [250ml]

1 teaspoon safflower or canola oil

2 teaspoons finely minced fresh ginger

1 cup Merlot [250ml]

2 to 3 tablespoons unrefined cane sugar

Vanilla ice cream

1. In a nonreactive medium skillet, **cook** the berries in the oil over medium heat for a minute or so, stirring often.
2. Add the ginger and continue to cook and stir for another minute. **Add** the wine and bring to a boil. Cook until the berries are softened, about 2 minutes.
3. Mash the berries with the back of a large spoon. **Stir** in the sugar—the amount you add will depend on the sweetness of the berries—and continue to cook until the wine is substantially reduced and the sauce is thickened.
4. **Spoon** over vanilla ice cream and serve at once.

SERVES 4

Summer compote with cashew vanilla crème

For best results, make this comforting but **luxurious** dessert the night before and serve it chilled. The Cashew Crème is also best when made ahead; give it at least 2 to 3 hours to chill. In preparing the fruit, you may choose to leave on the skin. I prefer to peel most fruits except those with soft skins, like peaches.

1 tart apple, peeled and cut into large dice

1 cup diced peeled mango [150g]

1 cup diced peach [150g]

½ cup sliced strawberries, cut in half or quarters, depending on size [70g]

1 cup apple juice [250ml]

½ cup unrefined cane sugar [100g]

1 tablespoon lemon juice

Cashew Vanilla Crème (recipe follows)

1. Put the apple, mango, peach, and strawberries into a medium saucepan. **Add** the apple juice, sugar and 1 cup [250ml] water; bring to a boil, stirring to dissolve the sugar. Reduce the heat and simmer, stirring occasionally, until the fruit is tender but still holds its shape, 5 to 7 minutes. With a slotted spoon, transfer the fruit to a bowl.
2. Bring the liquid in the saucepan to a boil. **Cook** for 10 to 15 minutes, or until reduced and syrupy. Stir in the lemon juice and pour over the fruit. Cover and refrigerate until chilled, several hours or, preferably, overnight.
3. To serve, **spoon** the compote into individual dessert bowls and top with a dollop of Cashew Vanilla Crème.

SERVES 4

Cashew vanilla crème

¾ cup raw unsalted cashews [90g]

2 tablespoons fresh lemon juice

½ cup apple juice [125ml]

½ teaspoon vanilla extract

2 tablespoons light-colored unrefined cane sugar

1. **Puree** all the ingredients in a blender or food processor until creamy and smooth. The key here is the blending. Just keep blending and scraping down the sides and blending some more for 2 or 3 minutes.
2. Transfer to a small bowl. **Cover** and refrigerate until chilled.

SERVES 4

chef's tip

Add a bit more lemon juice or a little water if the cream is too thick.